



PRAKASH PURB

Ninth Guru

Sri Guru Tegh Bahadur Ji

“ Sri Guru Tegh Bahadur Ji’s life is a shining example of the protection of humanity and religious freedom. His life inspires us to stand fearlessly against injustice and remain steadfast on the path of truth. Let us walk on the path shown by Guru Sahib and imbibe the values of brotherhood and humanity in our lives. ”

Bhagwant Singh Mann
Chief Minister, Punjab



AS TRUMP'S DEADLINE APPROACHES

Iranian petrochemical plant hit by Israeli airstrike in South Pars

TEHRAN: Israel struck a key petrochemical plant at Iran's massive South Pars natural gas field and killed two paramilitary Revolutionary Guard commanders on Monday, potentially challenging a new 45-day ceasefire proposal for Tehran and the United States as President Donald Trump's ultimatum looms within hours.

The gas field attack was aimed at eliminating a major source of revenue for Iran, Israel said. The field is critical to Iran's electricity production, but the strike appeared to be separate from Trump's threats to target power plants and bridges if Tehran doesn't reopen the Strait of Hormuz to all shipping traffic.

Iran's grip on the strait has caused oil prices to surge and shaken the world economy. Israel's Defence Minister Israel Katz described "a powerful strike on the largest petrochemical facility in Iran." The gas field shared with Qatar is the world's largest and sits under the Persian Gulf. Iranian state media confirmed the attack and blamed the US and Israel.

The White House did not



REPRESENTATIONAL IMAGE OF THE PETROCHEMICAL PLANT

immediately comment, though Trump was set to speak to journalists Monday afternoon, his first public appearance since Wednesday.

He had been relatively quiet during the rescue of downed US aviators in Iran.

After Israel's attack on the field in March, Trump said

Iran would not attack it again but warned that if Iran continued striking Qatar's energy infrastructure, the United States would "massively blow up" the field.

Trump's deadline for Tehran to reopen the Strait of Hormuz is set for Monday night Washington time.

Egyptian, Pakistani and Turkish mediators have sent Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi and US Mideast envoy Steve Witkoff a proposal calling for a 45-day ceasefire and the reopening of the strait, two Mideast officials told The Associated Press.

The officials spoke on con-

Highlights

» The gas field attack was reportedly aimed at eliminating a major source of revenue for Iran

» Iran's grip on the strait has caused oil prices to surge and shaken the world economy

» Israel's Defence Minister Israel Katz described "a powerful strike on the largest petrochemical facility in Iran"

IRANIAN STATE MEDIA CONFIRMED THE ATTACK AND BLAMED THE US AND ISRAEL

dition of anonymity to discuss the private negotiations.

Iran's foreign ministry spokesman Esmail Baghaei told journalists in Tehran that messages are being exchanged with mediators but "negotiations are entirely incompatible with ultimatums, crimes, and threats of war crimes."

AGENCIES

Russian attacks kill 4 as Ukraine drones target oil infrastructure

KYIV: A Russian drone attack on Ukraine's southern port city of Odesa killed two women and a toddler, authorities said on Monday, while Ukrainian long-range drones targeted Russia's key Black Sea port for oil exports.

The nighttime attack on Odesa heavily damaged an apartment block, killing the women and a 2-year-old child, officials said. Rescuers working under floodlights pulled four people from the rubble.

Eleven people were hospitalised, including a pregnant woman and two children — the youngest less than a year old, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said in a post on X.

Russia has pounded civilian areas of Ukraine since it invaded its neighbour just over four years ago, killing more than 15,000 people, according to the United Nations.

Over the past week, Russia has launched at Ukraine more than 2,800 attack drones, nearly 1,350 powerful glide bombs and more than 40 missiles of various types, according to Zelenskyy.

In the southern city of Kherson, Russian shelling killed an elderly woman and three other women, 86, 79 and 44, were hospitalised, according to Oleksandr Prokudin, head of the regional military



Representational Image

Russia has pounded civilian areas of Ukraine since it invaded its neighbour just over four years ago, killing more than 15,000 people, according to UN

More than 300,000 households were without electricity in northern Chernihiv after distribution facilities were damaged in the attacks, according to the regional power utility.

Zelenskyy expressed concern in a weekend interview with The Associated Press that the war in the Middle East is draining stockpiles of weapons that Ukraine needs to defend itself, especially American-made Patriot air defence systems that can stop missiles.

Zelenskyy said Monday that the country's partners "need to strengthen air defence together so that the interception rate of drones and missiles continues to increase."

With US-led peace efforts stalled, Zelenskyy added: "Russia has no intention of stopping" its invasion.

AGENCIES

Death toll from extreme weather in Afghanistan increases to 110

KABUL: The death toll from extreme weather that has triggered widespread flooding and landslides in many parts of Afghanistan has increased to at least 110, authorities said Monday, with another seven people missing and more heavy rain forecast.

Storms and heavy rainfall began across Afghanistan about 12 days ago, affecting most of the country's 34 provinces.

Over the past 24 hours alone, 11 people have died and six have been injured, the Disaster Management Authority said. Seven people were reported missing in separate incidents, all believed to have been carried away by floodwater.

AGENCIES

US Prez Trump endorses Republican Steven Hilton for California governor

LOS ANGELES: President Donald Trump has endorsed Republican Steve Hilton for California governor, reordering a crowded, wide-open race to lead the nation's most populous state. Trump posted late Sunday on his social media platform Truth Social that he has known Hilton for years and called the conservative commentator "a truly fine man" who could turn around a state beset with notoriously high taxes. California, Trump wrote, "has gone to hell."

"With Federal help, and a Great Governor, like Steve Hilton, California can be better than ever before!" Trump added. The endorsement will help Hilton coalesce conservative support in a race with no clear leader. However, Trump is widely unpopular in heav-

“WITH FEDERAL HELP, AND A GREAT GOVERNOR, LIKE STEVE HILTON, CALIFORNIA CAN BE BETTER THAN EVER BEFORE!”

ily Democratic California outside his conservative base and Trump's backing would become a liability if Hilton faces a Democrat in the November election.

With a large field, Democrats have been fearful that a quirk in the state's unusual "top two" primary system could allow only two Republicans to reach the November general election ballot — Hilton and GOP rival Chad.

AGENCIES

Neuroscience explains why teens so vulnerable to social media platforms

TORONTO: In a landmark decision, a Los Angeles jury has found that social media company Meta and video streaming service YouTube harmed a young user with addictive design features that led to mental health distress, including body dysmorphia, depression and suicidal thoughts.

Commentators have referred to this as social media's "Big Tobacco" moment, and further lawsuits are pending. The verdict has escalated calls for more regulation of social media platforms across jurisdictions.

Countries like Australia, France and Spain have already introduced age restrictions for social media use. Canada still lacks online harms legislation.

As parents campaign and policymakers consider how to address online harms, one



crucial question is often overlooked: Why are teenagers so uniquely vulnerable to these platforms in the first place?

Dopamine hits the immature pathways

Imagine Sara, who at 14 was found unconscious on her bedroom floor after an attempt to take her own life. By every measure, she was thriving: strong in school, supported by family, living in a vibrant community.

Key Points

» Commentators have referred to this as social media's 'Big Tobacco' moment

» One spent hours scrolling, posting and chasing likes until the validation stopped coming

But behind her bedroom door, she was struggling with something no one could see. She spent hours scrolling, posting and chasing likes until the validation stopped coming.

A quiet sense of not being good enough slowly took root. Despite 150 online followers, she had no one she felt she could truly talk to. She became convinced she was completely alone.

AGENCIES

Israel kills chief of IRGC Intelligence

JERUSALEM: Defence Minister Israel Katz announced on Monday that the Israel Air Force assassinated the chief of the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps' Intelligence Majid Khademi as he threatened to hunt down the Iranian leaders "one by one."

In an address following a situational assessment meeting with Israel Defence Forces (IDF) Chief of Staff Lt Gen Eyal Zamir and senior military officials, Katz said, "The (Iranian) Revolutionary Guards shoot at civilians and we eliminate the heads of terrorists."

"Iran's leaders live with a sense of persecution. We will continue to hunt them down one by one," the Israeli minister warned.

Israel will continue to attack Iran's vital infrastructure to weaken its economic backbone and missile manufacturing capabilities, he said.

"We struck hard at the steel infrastructure and the petrochemical industry - and today and every day the continuation will come," Katz said.

Khademi entered the role of IRGC intel chief several months ago, following the killing of his predecessor Mohammad Kazemi by Israel during the June 2025 war.

Israel has assassinated several senior Iranian officials, including Supreme Leader Ayatollah Syed Ali Khamenei, who was killed in the opening salvo launched by the Jewish state and the US on February 28.

AGENCIES

‘Pak to repay \$4.8 bn in external obligations by June’

ISLAMABAD: Pakistan has made arrangements to repay \$4.8 billion in external obligations by June, including \$3.5 billion payable to the UAE through three different facilities, a local media report said.

The development comes after the federal government decided to return \$2 billion to Abu Dhabi by the end of the current month.

The amount had been placed with the State Bank of Pakistan (SBP) as a deposit, on which the country has been paying around 6 per cent interest.

CLOSER LOOK

» The development comes after the federal government decided to return \$2 billion to Abu Dhabi by the end of the current month

» Islamabad also received assurances of more than \$5 billion in financial support from two friendly countries

Islamabad also received assurances of more than \$5 billion in financial support from two friendly countries to help manage its external financing requirements, Geo News reported on Monday, citing sources. A \$1.3 billion Euro-

bond, issued for a 10-year period, is maturing this week and will be repaid accordingly, adding to near-term repayment pressures, it said.

In the past, the UAE had rolled over such deposits annually. However, in Decem-

ber 2025, the facility was extended only for short durations — initially for one month and then for two months — reflecting tightening financial conditions.

The UAE recently sought the immediate return of the funds amid the evolving situation in West Asia following the US-Israel war on Iran, sources said.

Earlier, the UAE had agreed in principle to roll over the \$2 billion deposit for a short-term period of two months after Deputy Prime Minister Ishaq Dar engaged with the UAE authori-

ties. The rollover was extended until April 17, 2026.

Previously, \$1 billion each maturing on February 16 and February 22 had been rolled over for one month. Another tranche of \$1 billion is due to mature in July 2026.

The Abu Dhabi Fund for Development has placed a total of \$3 billion with the SBP in three tranches. Two tranches that matured in January were rolled over for a month, while the third will be addressed closer to its maturity, the report said.

AGENCIES

THE STRONGEST ASSESSMENT YET

Seoul believes teen daughter of North Korea's Kim to be his 'fairly' heir

SEOUL: South Korea's spy agency says it's now fair to view the teenage daughter of North Korean leader Kim Jong Un as his heir, its strongest assessment yet on the rising political status of the girl who it believes could extend her family's rule into a fourth generation.

The girl, dubbed by state media as Kim's "most beloved" or "respected" child, has accompanied her



father to numerous high-profile events since late 2022, sparking outside speculation that she's being groomed as

the North's future leader. In a closed-door briefing at the National Assembly, South Korea's National Intelligence Service director Lee Jong-seok said the girl could be considered as Kim's successor in response to questions by lawmakers about her political standing, according to Lee Seong Kweun, one of the lawmakers who attended the meeting.

AGENCIES

Declare TTP terrorist body, Pak tells Taliban

LAHORE: Pakistan has demanded that Afghanistan formally declare TTP as a terrorist organisation and dismantle its infrastructure as a precondition to resolve the ongoing border conflict between the two countries, local media reported on Monday.

Islamabad put forward three core demands last week during a meeting between representatives of Pakistan and the Afghan Taliban in the Chinese city of Urumqi. The Express Tribune newspaper reported.

The China-facilitated talks are the first major diplomatic engagement between the two neighbours since Pakistan launched Operation Ghazab lil-Haq in late February to target terrorist "hideouts" in Afghanistan. The talks represent a cautious but important effort to stabilise Pakistan-Afghanistan ties.

"The three demands put forward by Islamabad include Kabul formally declaring the Tehreek-

e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP) a terrorist organisation, dismantling its infrastructure, and providing verifiable proof of the action," the report said, quoting sources.

These demands form the basis of Pakistan's negotiating position, which has hardened amid persistent security concerns, the sources said.

According to the report, a framework is under discussion that could pave the way for a possible understanding between the two sides.

It includes a "ceasefire arrangement, counterterrorism assurances from the Afghan Taliban, dismantling of terror sanctuaries inside Afghanistan, and measures to facilitate secure trade routes".

It also envisages the establishment of a more structured and institutionalised dialogue mechanism between Islamabad and Kabul, as both sides have sent technical-level delegations to Urumqi, reflecting the operational nature of the discussions.

AGENCIES

Imran Khan's party, rights body demand inquiry into killing of over 1,000 people

Staged encounters were executed by police force formed by Maryam Nawaz

LAHORE: Pakistan Tehreek-i-Insaf founder Imran Khan and the Human Rights Commission of Pakistan (HRCP) have called for an immediate judicial inquiry into the killing of over 1,000 people in "staged encounters" by a special police force formed by Punjab Chief Minister Maryam Nawaz.

According to an official of HRCP, over 1,000 suspects have been killed by Punjab's Crime Control Department (CCD) through "staged encounters" during the last year with impunity. "The CCD has adopted a deliberate policy of staged police encounters leading to extrajudicial killing," an official of HRCP said on Monday.

In 2025, he said the CCD conducted 670 encounters in Punjab that resulted in the deaths of 924 suspects, while only two police officials were killed during the same timeframe in these encounters.



"This tally has crossed the 1,000 mark this year," he added.

On the other hand, the Pakistan Tehreek-i-Insaf said Maryam's CCD could kill anyone anytime in the province with total impunity, establishing a law of the jungle in Pakistan. It cited the recent killing of a Spanish national of Pakistani origin (Nauman Qaisar) who was affiliated with Tehreek-e-Insaf in a staged encounter by CCD.

"Mr Qaisar came to Pakistan to clear his name in a fake murder case against him, but the CCD Punjab Police bru-

KEY POINTS

» According to an official of HRCP, over 1,000 suspects have been killed by Punjab's Crime Control Department

» In 2025, the official said the CCD conducted 670 encounters in Punjab that resulted in the deaths of 924 suspects, while only two police officials were killed during the same timeframe in these encounters

tally killed him. The CCD has now become a group of hired assassins that can be used by anyone," PTI senior leader and former cabinet member Moonis Elahi posted on his X.

He sought justice for Qaisar, saying a judicial commission should be formed to probe such encounters and bring the culprits to justice.

Maryam last year formed the CCD, tasking it to bring down the crime rate in the province of 130 million people.

The HRCP said the sharp disparity in casualties — aver-

aging more than two fatal encounters per day — alongside similar operational patterns reported across districts of Punjab seems to be an "institutionalised practice" rather than isolated incidents of misconduct.

It said the special police force has created a "climate of fear among affected families". The relatives of some suspects killed in staged encounters are pressured by police to bury the deceased immediately and warned of further harm if they pursue legal action.

AGENCIES

World Briefs

UNIDENTIFIED GUNMEN KILL 3 POLICE OFFICERS IN NORTHWEST PAKISTAN

PESHAWAR: Unidentified gunmen on Monday killed three security personnel in two separate attacks in northwest Pakistan, police said. The attacks occurred in the Bannu district in restive Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province. According to a police official, the first incident occurred in the Kanger Jan Bahadur area of Mandan, where a police official was shot dead while on his way to duty. Law enforcement agencies rushed to the scene, cordoned off the area, and shifted the body to a nearby hospital, he added. A search operation was launched to nab the attackers.

RUSSIA TO START BUILDING NATIONAL ORBITAL STATION IN 2028

MOSCOW: Russia will start building its national orbital station ahead of the scheduled deorbiting of the International Space Station (ISS) in 2030, a top Russian space official said on Monday. The first module of the Russian Orbital Station (ROS) will be deployed in 2028, CEO of Russia's Roscosmos State Space Corporation Dmitry Rogozin said in an interview with the state-owned news agency TASS. Russia marks Space Week, starting Monday, to celebrate the 65th anniversary of the first human space flight by Soviet cosmonaut Yuri Gagarin on April 12, 1961.

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Committed to
Nari Shakti Vandan



We now have access to clean water



We now have a permanent home



We now have dignity

Tap water in 15.8+ crore homes

4+ crore homes with majority owned by women

12.1+ crore toilets built

Tehran rejects ceasefire proposal, Trump says Iran could be taken out in one night

Trump threatens to jail journalist who first reported on downed airman

ASSOCIATED PRESS

DUBAI/ WASHINGTON: Iran on Monday rejected the latest ceasefire proposal and instead said it wants a permanent end to the war, as US President Donald Trump's ultimatum loomed within hours.

Iran's state-run IRNA news agency said Tehran had conveyed its response through Pakistan, a key mediator.

"We won't merely accept a ceasefire," Mojtaba Ferdousi Pour, head of the Iranian diplomatic mission in Cairo, told The Associated Press. "We only accept an end of the war with guarantees that we won't be attacked again."

The response makes clear that Tehran is not open to a temporary truce, instead stressing the need for a "permanent end to war."



Israeli police inspect the damage to cars and an apartment building struck by an Iranian missile in Ramat Gan, Israel, on Monday

CLOSER LOOK

- » Tehran insists on guarantees against future attacks before any agreement
- » Response conveyed via Pakistan, acting as a key mediator
- » Iran outlines a 10-point framework beyond a temporary ceasefire
- » Proposal includes ending conflict in Lebanon & Gaza
- » Tehran seeks control over Strait of Hormuz and shipping toll rights
- » US deadline for agreement set for Tuesday, termed final by Trump
- » Washington signals military options remain open amid rising tensions
- » Iran rejects NUCLEAR WEAPON claims, calls programme peaceful

traffic and collect tolls from ships passing through the route.

Later on Monday, Trump said Iran could be "taken out" in a single night and suggested that such an operation "might" happen as soon as Tuesday evening, escalating rhetoric as tensions deepen.

"The entire country could be taken out in one night, and that night might be tomorrow night," Trump told reporters during a press conference, underscoring what he described as the United States' military capability.

The US President's remarks came as he detailed a high-risk US rescue operation inside Iran following the crash of an F-15 aircraft, in which two airmen ejected and landed "deep in enemy territory," Trump said the initial mission involved 21 aircraft flying

Bengal SIR: SC refuses to defer voter roll freeze despite 20L exclusions

Directed CJ of Cal HC to form 3-member panel of former senior judges to ensure uniform procedure

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOLKATA: The Supreme Court of India on Monday was told that about 45 per cent of nearly 40 lakh cases examined during the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in West Bengal have resulted in exclusion after adjudication by judicial officers, even as the court refused to extend the freezing of the voter list ahead of elections.

A Bench comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justices Joydip Bagchi and Vipul Pancholi was informed by the Chief Justice of the Calcutta High Court, Sujoy Paul, that 59.15 lakh cases had been decided out of 60.06 lakh, leaving around 26,000 pending, with the process set to con-

BENGAL SIR

- » Senior Advocate Shyam Divan said data of about 40 lakh cases shows an inclusion rate of 55 per cent (around 24 lakh), while roughly 45 per cent—about 20 lakh—were excluded
- » He added that around seven lakh appeals have been filed, with several lakh more expected, even as appellate tribunals are yet to be fully operational

clude the same day.

Senior Advocate Shyam Divan said data of about 40 lakh cases shows



Modi govt's handling of 'LPG crisis' is like it dealt with Covid pandemic; puts burden on poor

Rahul Gandhi

In today's paper

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PM highlights reform agenda, says work on UCC and poll synchronisation in progress

Says positive discussions ongoing

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Monday said that key political reforms such as the Uniform Civil Code and the proposal for simultaneous elections remain active priorities, with discussions progressing and "tremendous" headway made so far. Addressing party workers virtually on the Bharatiya Janata Party's 47th Foundation Day, he framed these initiatives as part of a broader agenda aimed at long-term national transformation.

"Our mission is still ongoing. On Uniform Civil Code, 'One Nation, One Election' and other issues, serious discussions are taking place in the country," Modi said, adding that progress had been made on multiple fronts. The proposed "One Nation, One Election" framework seeks to align Lok Sabha and state assembly polls, while the Uniform Civil Code aims to introduce a common set of personal laws governing matters such as marriage and adoption across religions.

Highlighting legislative priorities, the prime minister said the government is committed to implementing the Women's Reservation Act in the 2029 general elections. The law provides for 33 per cent reservation for women in the Lok Sabha and state assemblies. Modi noted that the BJP had first raised the demand for women's reservation in 1994 in Vadodara and had since worked to increase women's participation within the party.



OUR MISSION IS STILL ONGOING. ON UNIFORM CIVIL CODE, 'ONE NATION, ONE ELECTION' AND OTHER ISSUES, SERIOUS DISCUSSIONS ARE TAKING PLACE IN THE COUNTRY

Turning to the party's history, Modi said BJP workers had faced adversity during periods such as the Emergency under Congress rule. He also referred to incidents of political violence in states including West Bengal and Kerala, where he said several party workers had lost their lives. Targeting the Congress, he said such experiences had shaped the BJP's evolution and strengthened its organisational resolve.

The prime minister listed a series of decisions taken by his government, including the repeal of colonial-era laws,

NOTICES SIGNED BY 193 MPs AGAINST CEC REJECTED

Parl rejects Opposition move to oust CEC

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla and Rajya Sabha Chairman C P Radhakrishnan on Monday declined to admit separate notices moved by opposition members seeking the removal of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar.

The notices, submitted in both Houses on March 12, 2026, accused the CEC of "partisan and discriminatory conduct in office", along with "deliberate obstruction of

A similar decision was conveyed by the Lok Sabha Secretariat regarding the notice signed by 130 Members of Parliament

investigation of electoral fraud" and "mass disenfranchisement". Opposition parties have also alleged that recent actions by the Election Commission, particularly the Special Inten-

sive Revision of electoral rolls, were intended to benefit the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party.

According to an official communication issued by the Rajya Sabha Secretariat, the notice signed by 63 members of the Upper House was examined under Article 324(5) of the Constitution. After reviewing the motion, the Chairman declined to admit it. "After due consideration of the notice of Motion and a careful and objective assessment of all relevant aspects and issues involved, the Chairman, Rajya Sabha... has

refused to admit the said notice of Motion," the statement said, citing powers under the Judges (Inquiry) Act, 1968.

A similar decision was conveyed by the Lok Sabha Secretariat regarding the notice signed by 130 Members of Parliament. The motion, also dated March 12, invoked Article 324(5) alongside Article 124(4), provisions of the Chief Election Commissioner and Other Election Commissioners Act, 2023, and the Judges (Inquiry) Act, 1968.

3 HELD, VEHICLE SEIZED

Masked man breaches Delhi Assembly security, drops bouquet in Speaker's car

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A security scare unfolded at the Delhi Assembly on Monday afternoon when a masked man drove an SUV through a boundary gate, briefly accessed the premises, and left behind a flower bouquet in the Speaker's official vehicle before fleeing. The incident, which lasted only a few minutes, prompted a high alert and a large-scale security response.

Police said the vehicle, bearing a Uttar Pradesh registration from Pilibhit, broke through Gate No. 2 around 2 pm. Officials described the driving as reckless, with the



Police personnel inspect a flower bouquet

SUV approaching from the Delhi University side, taking a sharp turn, and crashing through boom barriers to enter the complex.

According to sources, the

KEY POINTS

- » Masked man drove an SUV into Delhi Assembly through Gate No. 2 around 2 pm
- » Vehicle broke boom barriers and entered premises in a matter of minutes

Sathankulam custodial deaths: Court sentences 9 cops to death

MPOST BUREAU

MADURAI (Tamil Nadu): In a significant ruling, a court in Tamil Nadu on Monday sentenced nine police personnel to death in connection with the 2020 custodial deaths of a father and son in Sathankulam, a case that had triggered nationwide outrage.

First Additional District and Sessions Judge G Muthukumar described the crime as falling under the "rarest of rare" category, stating that those entrusted with upholding the law had committed an act that "shook the collective conscience of society". The court held all nine accused guilty of murdering P Jayaraj and his son J Bennis.

The case dates back to June 2020, when the duo, who ran a mobile phone shop in Sathankulam in Thoothukudi district, were detained by police for allegedly violating COVID-19 restrictions by keeping their store open beyond permitted hours. They were subjected to severe custodial violence and later succumbed to their injuries at a hospital.

Among those convicted are former inspector S Sridhar, former sub-inspectors Balakrishnan and Raghu Ganesh, along with head constables Murugan and Saamidurai. One of the original 10 accused, special sub inspector Pauldurai, died during the course of the trial due to health complications.

SC orders CBI enquiry into contracts awarded to firms linked to Arunachal CM's kin

Says state does not hold public resources as 'private proprietor' but as trustee on behalf of people

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Monday ordered a preliminary enquiry by the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) into allegations that public works contracts in Arunachal Pradesh were awarded to firms linked to family members of Chief Minister Pema Khandu, directing that the probe be initiated within two weeks and cover a decade of transactions.

A bench led by Justice Vikram Nath, along with Justices Sandeep Mehta and N V Anjaria, said the enquiry would examine the award and execution of public works, contracts and work orders in the state between January 1, 2015 and December 31, 2025. The court also asked the CBI to submit a status report within 16 weeks. "The CBI shall register a PE within two weeks from the date of the judgement and will proceed in accordance with law," Justice Nath said while pronouncing the order. The detailed judgement, which runs into 35 pages, is awaited in full.

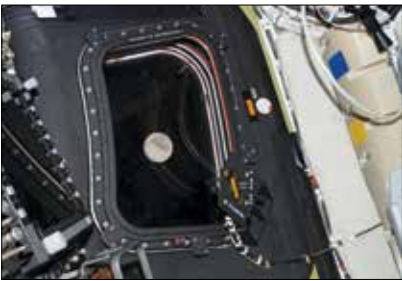
The direction came on a petition filed by NGOs Save Mon Region Federation and Voluntary Arunachal Sena, which alleged that contracts worth around Rs 1,270 crore over the past ten years were awarded to four firms connected to the chief minister's family. Senior advocate Prashant Bhushan, appearing for the petitioners, relied on an



Artemis II beats Apollo 13 record, sends humans farthest from Earth

HOUSTON: A 56-year-old record for the farthest distance travelled by humans from Earth was broken on Monday as NASA's Artemis II astronauts swept past the moon during a historic lunar flyby, marking a major milestone in humanity's return to deep space exploration. The four-member crew surpassed the previous record of 248,655 miles set by Apollo 13 in April 1970, with Mission Control estimating the new mark exceeded it by more than 4,100 miles.

The achievement came just ahead of the mission's six-hour fly-around of the moon, the centerpiece of NASA's first crewed lunar mission since Apollo 17 in 1972. As



In this photo provided by NASA, the Moon is seen in the window of the Orion spacecraft, photo taken by The Artemis II crew

their Orion spacecraft approached the lunar surface, the astronauts witnessed expansive views of the far side of the moon, a region never

directly seen from Earth. The crew includes three Americans, Commander Reid Wiseman, pilot Victor Glover, and

HIGHLIGHTS

- » The mission features four astronauts: Reid Wiseman, Victor Glover, Christina Koch, and Canada's Jeremy Hansen
- » Crew set a new human distance record from Earth, surpassing Apollo 13's 248,655 miles (400,171 km)

SC declines to stay Adani's ₹14,535 cr acquisition of JAL

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Monday refused to halt the implementation of the Adani Group's Rs 14,535-crore resolution plan for debt-laden Jaiprakash Associates Limited (JAL), while putting in place a safeguard to ensure oversight during the ongoing legal dispute.

A bench led by Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice Joydip Bagchi directed that JAL's monitoring committee must seek prior approval from the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) before taking any "major policy decisions". The court also asked both Vedanta Ltd and Adani Enterprises Ltd to pres-

The court noted that the appellant's interests were adequately protected and that no further directions were necessary

ent their arguments before the appellate tribunal, which is scheduled to begin final hearings on April 10.

"In view of the fact that the company appeals are now listed for final hearing at the NCLAT on April 10, 2026, we see no reason to interfere with the impugned order," the bench said, while urging the tribunal to hear the matter on an out-of-turn basis and conclude

23 FOREIGN FIREARMS SEIZED

Two arrested at IGLA in ISI-linked arms trafficking case

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: Two key operatives of a transnational arms trafficking and terror module, allegedly backed by Pakistan's Inter-Services Intelligence (ISI), have been arrested by the Delhi Police Crime Branch at Indira Gandhi International (IGI) Airport.

Acting on a tip-off, the Crime Branch apprehended the accused—Imran (37), a resident of Sikandrabad, Bulandshahr, and Moham-mad Kamran (27), also from Bulandshahr—after Look Out Circulars were issued against them in connection with an ongoing probe into an international arms smuggling network.

The arrests were made by the Anti-Robbery and Snatching Cell (ARSC) of the Crime Branch, led by Inspectors Man Singh and Sunder Gautam



under the supervision of ACP Sanjay Kumar Nagpal.

The case relates to an FIR registered on March 14 under provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, the Arms Act, and the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA).

Sections 15, 16 and 18 of the UAPA were invoked on March 31 based on developments in

the investigation.

Police said the accused were key members of an international arms trafficking module allegedly run by kingpin Shah-baz Ansari. With their arrest, the total number of accused held in the case has risen to 12. So far, investigators have recovered 23 sophisticated foreign-made firearms, including

HIGHLIGHTS

- » During interrogation, Imran and Kamran allegedly revealed their role in procuring illegal weapons from Nepal and smuggling them into India via covert routes
- » Weapons were transported in dismantled form to evade detection and later reassembled before being supplied

a submachine gun, along with 211 live cartridges.

During interrogation, Imran and Kamran allegedly revealed their role in procuring illegal weapons from Nepal and smuggling them into India through covert routes. The weapons were transported in dismantled form to evade detection and later reassembled

before being supplied to criminal and anti-national elements across Delhi-NCR and other parts of the country.

Based on their disclosures, police recovered a Maruti Swift car from Bulandshahr that had specially fabricated hidden cavities used for concealing arms. A .30 bore Chinese-made pistol with five cartridges was recovered at Imran's instance, while a .32 bore revolver with six cartridges was recovered at Kamran's instance.

Investigators suspect the network operated under the guidance of foreign handlers linked to the ISI, with weapons allegedly routed from Pakistan via Thailand and Nepal before being smuggled into India.

Further investigation is underway to dismantle the network and identify other associates involved in the cross-border arms trafficking conspiracy.

GURUGRAM MINOR'S RAPE

SC stresses plainclothes visit to avoid trauma to minor girl

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Observing that the case involves serious issues and that it is not going to drop the proceedings at the moment, the Supreme Court on Monday asked the SIT probing the alleged rape case of a three-year-old in Gurugram to visit the minor's residence in plain clothes, accompanied by a psychologist, to record her statement.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice Joy-malya Bagchi granted two weeks to the all-women Special Investigation Team (SIT) to complete the probe. It also directed the trial court not to entertain any bail application of the accused till the SIT files its chargesheet.

"The SIT members should visit along with child counsellors... Please go in civilian clothes...the child should not have any psychological impact. Have a cup of tea with the parents and interact with the child," the CJI said.



The SIT informed the court that polygraph test reports of the three accused are expected in about a week and that it needs to interact with the child. It added that while Gurugram police had earlier sought a test identification parade, it is not seeking one now.

Senior advocate Gopal San-karanarayanan and advocate Sumeer Sodhi, appearing for the doctor who examined the child and was earlier pulled up by the court for allegedly changing her statement, said she is an 80-year-old reputed medical practitioner and has not altered her version. They sought the dropping of proceedings against her.

The bench, however, said, "We are not going to drop the proceedings against anyone at the moment, and this case will be remembered in the whole country as an example".

It listed the matter for further hearing on April 27.

On March 25, castigating the Haryana Police for its "shameful" and "insensitive" approach in the rape case of the child, the top court constituted an SIT of women IPS officers to conduct a fair investigation.

It asked the Haryana government to immediately notify the SIT and directed the Gurugram police to hand over the case records to the probe panel.

The Supreme Court rapped Haryana Police for down-grading charges and criticised a doctor for changing her statement.

Notices were issued to officials over lapses. A three-year-old was allegedly abused for months by domestic helps and an accomplice, with the FIR registered in February after disclosure.

Attempt to torch house caught on camera, cops say two accused have been identified

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police has identified two men who attempted to set a residential house on fire in northwest Delhi's Adarsh Nagar and will arrest them soon, officials said on Tuesday.

Prima facie, it appears that the accused committed the act without any provocation, they said. The incident was reported to Adarsh Nagar police station on April 5.

The complainant alleged an attempt by miscreants to torch

One footage showed two men pouring a flammable liquid from a plastic bottle on the one-storeyed residential building

his house. The incident caused no injuries as the family members quickly managed to douse the fire using water.

During the preliminary inquiry, police examined CCTV footage from surrounding areas. One footage showed two men pouring a flammable liquid from a plastic bottle on the one-storeyed residen-

tial building, before lighting a matchstick and throwing it onto the house.

Flames quickly engulfed parts of the house, including its entry gate. However, the inhabitants who emerged from the house promptly threw water and doused the fire.

"We have identified the accused. We also talked to the

family whose house was set on fire. They told police that they don't know the accused and have no enmity with anyone," a police officer said. Police said evidence confirmed that the fire was not accidental and the men planned to cause the damage without provocation.

Based on the complainant's statement and technical evidence, a case has been registered under sections related to causing grievous damage and endangering life and property, and for acts involving fire or explosive substances.

21-year-old man killed, 2 injured after speeding truck hits scooter

OUR CORRESPONDENT

GURUGRAM: A 21-year-old man was killed, and his two companions were injured when a speeding truck hit their scooter on Monday, police said.

According to the police, the deceased was identified as Kul-deep (21), a native of Madhya Pradesh. He worked for a private company in Gurugram and lived in a rented house in Sikanderpur Badha village.

The accident took place near Jai Singh Chowk at around 2:50 am on Mon-

'Accident took place near Jai Singh Chowk at 2:50 am on Monday when all three men were headed on a scooter'

day when all three men were headed to their destination on a scooter. A speeding truck coming from behind hit their scooter, police said.

Kuldeep, the scooter rider, died on the spot, while two

others accompanying him sustained minor injuries, they said. People present nearby immediately informed the police and took the injured to the nearest hospital, where they were given first aid.

An FIR was registered at Kherki Daula police station against the unidentified truck driver who managed to flee from the spot, they added.

"We handed over the body to the kin after the post-mortem. The accused truck driver will be arrested soon", said a senior police officer.

DU may open UG admissions in 3rd week of May

NEW DELHI: Admissions in undergraduate programmes of Delhi University are likely to start from the third week of May, shortly after the Common University Entrance Test (UG) 2026 begins, officials said on Monday.

They said the university conducts its admission process through the Common Seat Allocation System (CSAS) portal, and the admission takes place in multiple phases, the first being registration.

The admission through the CSAS portal is mostly dependent on the CUET results, following which students can apply for the eligible subjects after subject mapping, they added.

According to the information from the National Testing Agency, the CUET-UG 2026 is set to tentatively take place between May 11 and 31.

DU dean of admission Haneet Gandhi told PTI, "The registration process for DU will begin once the CUET exams begin, so hopefully we will open the portal for registration around the third week of May. While details are still being confirmed, our primary focus, just like last year, will

be on finishing the admission on time so classes can begin at the earliest".

"We will try to shorten the allocation period as much as possible. Even if one or two days are adjusted per round, that should be enough," Gandhi added.

In recent years, university teachers have expressed major concern over delays in the admission process after DU shifted to a CUET score-based admission system. According to professors, this has caused significant disruption to the academic cycle.

Additionally, the university is working on making the CSAS portal "more student-friendly", Gandhi said.

"We will add more prompts to help guide the students along the process, so there are lesser mistakes," she said.

The dean of admissions further urged the students to choose their CUET paper subjects based on the subjects studied in class 12, as at least 50 per cent similarity of subjects between the two will be required for subject mapping, which is a crucial step in the DU admission through the CSAS portal. PTI

Man killed over brother's 'relationship' with married woman

NEW DELHI: An 18-year-old youth was allegedly stabbed to death in northwest Delhi's Jahangirpuri by four people over his elder brother's "friendship" with the wife of one of the accused, police said on Monday.

The victim was identified as Hasmat, while the accused were Dilshad, Irfan, Imran, all brothers, and Rizbul, their brother-in-law. All four

accused are currently absconding, they said.

The police said that Hakeem's -- the victim's brother -- alleged friendship with Rizbul's wife, Manwara, for the past five to six years led to the incident.

"Despite Hakeem's marriage to another woman in 2024, he continued the association, which caused tension between both sides," an offi-



Multiple teams have been formed to trace & apprehend the accused: Police

cer said. The situation wors-

ened during Eid when Hasmat went to the accused's home to confront them after Manwara allegedly abused his wife.

"Since then, the accused had held a grudge against him. On Sunday at around 6 pm, taking advantage of the situation, they attacked Hasmat at Ramliha Maidan," the officer said.

The victim was taken to Babu Jagjivan Ram Memorial

(BJRM) Hospital with multiple stab wounds and was declared dead, the police said.

"During inquiry, Hakeem, an eyewitness, said that Hasmat was attacked by the accused, following which a case was registered," the officer said.

The police said multiple teams have been formed to trace and apprehend the accused at the earliest. Further investigation is underway. MPOST

JNUSU and JNUTA report finds V-C Pandit guilty, seek removal

NEW DELHI: The Jawaharlal Nehru University (JNU) Students' Union (JNUSU) and Teachers' Association (JNUTA) on Monday released the report of a public inquiry against the vice chancellor that had been conducted on March 16 and 18.

The report, which delves into details of allegations against the vice chancellor, concluded, "... the Vice Chancellor of Jawaharlal Nehru University, Professor Santishree Dhulipudi Pandit, is guilty of all the charges framed by the JNUSU and JNUTA. Based on the evidence presented, it is a fit case for making a formal demand for her removal from the office she occupies."

No immediate response was available from the VC's office.

Campus has recently been embroiled in multiple controversies

The JNU campus has recently been embroiled in multiple controversies, starting from early February this year, when the four office-bearers of JNUSU and an ex-president of the students' union were rusticated due to "permanent damage to university property" during a previous protest.

This was compounded manifold with the protests that followed, and the alleged casteist remarks made by the JNU VC.

Subsequently, the public inquiry was held to dis-

cuss the allegations against the VC and deliberate on the JNUSU's demand that the VC should resign.

According to the report produced on Monday, JNUSU and JNUTA had formally requested the VC to join the proceedings "to defend herself against the framed charges".

"However, she neither responded nor defended herself in the public inquiry... This public inquiry against the vice chancellor was planned as a mode of protest modelled on an official inquiry but deriving its legitimacy not from powers vested in any statutory authority but from the collective sentiment of students and teachers of JNU," the report mentioned. PTI

16 malaria, 59 dengue cases reported in city so far this year: MCD

NEW DELHI: Delhi has reported 16 malaria, 59 dengue and two chikungunya cases so far this year, according to a civic report.

No deaths have been recorded due to any of the three diseases, the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) said in its weekly report for the period ending April 4.

According to the report, malaria cases have declined from 26 during the corresponding period last year to 16 this year.

One fresh malaria case was reported last week. Dengue and chikungunya cases have also remained sporadic, officials



said, noting that the numbers are being closely tracked as part of routine surveillance.

The civic agency compiles weekly data across areas under MCD, New Delhi Municipal Council, Delhi Cantonment and railways to monitor the spread of vector-borne diseases in the capital. MPOST

Violence erupted during the protests against CAA, NRC

The HC had also said that those accused who have secured bail in the case were delaying arguments on the charge "at the cost of those accused persons who are in prison." Besides Ahmed, activists Umar Khalid and Sharjeel Imam, and several others were booked under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA) and provisions of IPC for allegedly being the "masterminds" of the February 2020 riots in Delhi, which left 53 people dead and over 700 injured.

The violence erupted during the protests against the CAA and NRC.

ORTHOPAEDICS QUARTERLY MEET

Orthopaedic experts to gather at AIIMS

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Department of Orthopaedics at the All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS), New Delhi is set to host the POF Quarterly Meet 2026, bringing together medical professionals and experts in the field of orthopaedics. The event, scheduled to be held at the institute's SET Facility, reflects AIIMS' continued emphasis on academic exchange and clinical advancement.

According to information



Meet will focus on the theme 'Knotty Bone Lesions Pedipod's Nightmare,' highlighting complex orthopaedic conditions and challenges in diagnosis, treatment

shared by the institute, the meet will focus on the theme "Knotty Bone Lesions Pedipod's Nightmare," highlighting complex orthopaedic conditions and challenges in diagnosis and treatment. Such academic gatherings are considered crucial platforms for discussing evolu-

ting techniques, sharing case studies, and fostering collaboration among specialists.

Events like the Quarterly Meet form part of a broader calendar of orthopaedic conferences and teaching programmes held across the country, aimed at strengthen-

ing clinical expertise and innovation in the discipline.

The upcoming session is expected to see participation from faculty members, researchers, and postgraduate students, further reinforcing AIIMS' role as a hub for advanced medical learning.

INITIATIVE AIMS TO BOOST SAFETY, CLEANLINESS AND AESTHETICS

Delhi govt to redevelop neglected flyover stretches under CSR push

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a major urban makeover push, the Delhi government on Monday signed a key MoU to transform neglected spaces beneath flyovers into vibrant public zones, with Chief Minister Rekha Gupta calling it a step towards a “clean and beautiful Delhi.”

The agreement was formalised at the Delhi Secretariat in the presence of senior officials, marking a significant public-private collaboration to improve the city’s urban landscape. The Public Works Department (PWD) has partnered under CSR initiatives with Dalmia Bharat Limited, Godrej Industries Group and EaseMyTrip Foundation to execute the project.

The initiative aims to convert underutilised and often neglected flyover stretches into organised, visually appealing



and functional public spaces. These areas will feature landscaped green zones, wall murals, seating arrangements, sanitation systems and other civic amenities.

Addressing the event, Gupta said, “The plan is to convert neglected spaces under flyovers into vibrant, functional

areas for public use.” She added, “This initiative will not only improve Delhi’s aesthetics but also encourage greater public awareness and participation in maintaining cleanliness.” Emphasising collaboration, she noted that “public-private partnerships will help transform the capital into a modern,

HIGHLIGHTS

- » Addressing the event, Gupta said, ‘The plan is to convert neglected spaces under flyovers into vibrant, functional areas for public use’
- » She added, ‘This initiative will not only improve Delhi’s aesthetics but also encourage greater public awareness and participation in maintaining cleanliness’

clean and attractive city.”

PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh described the project as a step towards reshaping Delhi’s infrastructure. He said, “Beautifying under-flyover spaces will enhance the city’s appearance and make these areas safer and more useful for the public,” adding that the

government is committed to building a “clean, well-organised and world-class Delhi.”

Under the project, multiple flyover stretches will be redeveloped. The EaseMyTrip Foundation will work on the Apsara Border and Mayur Vihar Phase-1 flyovers, while Godrej Industries Group will develop the Netaji Subhash Place flyover stretch. Dalmia Bharat Limited will undertake work at the Oberoi, Lodhi and Mangi Setu (Hanuman Setu) stretches.

At Mangi Setu, a Ramayana-themed visual journey will be showcased through murals, adding a cultural dimension to the redevelopment.

Officials said the initiative is aimed at creating citizen-friendly urban spaces while enhancing safety, cleanliness and aesthetics, positioning Delhi towards a more modern and sustainable urban future.

L-G, CM review energy, summer, monsoon prep

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Signalling a coordinated push for Delhi’s development and public welfare, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Monday met Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu at Lok Niwas, with discussions centred on energy security, seasonal preparedness and inter-agency coordination.

The high-level meeting focused on key governance priorities aligned with the vision of Narendra Modi for a “Viksit Bharat” and “Viksit Delhi.” Officials said the discussions were detailed and aimed at strengthening planning and execution across sectors impacting daily life in the capital.

On energy security, both sides stressed the need for close monitoring of LPG supply chains to ensure timely availability to consumers. Measures to curb black marketing were also discussed. In addition, expansion of PNG (piped natural gas) infrastructure was identified as a key step to address supply gaps



and improve access to cleaner fuel across the city.

Addressing seasonal challenges, the Chief Minister highlighted the importance of proactive planning. She said, “We are committed to ensuring that Delhi is fully prepared to tackle extreme weather conditions, including heatwaves and water stress.” The meeting reviewed the Summer Action Plan, with a focus on ensuring adequate drinking water supply and strengthening heatwave preparedness mechanisms.

Monsoon readiness was another major agenda point. Emphasis was laid on advance planning to prevent urban flooding, including timely completion of desilting of drains and improving drainage

infrastructure. Gupta stated, “Timely execution of desilting work and coordinated planning are critical to mitigating water-logging during the monsoon.”

The Chief Minister also underlined the need for seamless coordination among multiple agencies. She said, “Effective coordination between Delhi Government departments, urban local bodies, Central agencies and neighbouring states is essential for efficient governance and public service delivery.”

Officials said the CM and L-G agreed on a unified approach to tackle infrastructure and service delivery issues, aiming to boost coordination and speed up implementation of key public welfare initiatives.

Two posing as discom officials dupe Delhiite of over Rs 20 lakh

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Two cyber fraudsters were arrested for allegedly duping a east Delhi’s resident of over Rs 20 lakh by posing as electricity officials, police said on Monday.

According to the police, the complainant, Vinod Sharma, a resident of Mansarovar Park, received a call on March 8 from a person posing as an official of BSES for electricity meter updating. He was persuaded to pay Rs 13 online.

‘The accused have been identified as Shiv Kumar and Anshu Kumar, both residents of UP’s Firozabad district’

“Soon after the payment, Sharma’s mobile phone was compromised and multiple unauthorised transactions amounting to Rs 20.36 lakh were made from his bank accounts,” an officer said.

The accused have been identified as Shiv Kumar and Anshu Kumar, both residents of Uttar Pradesh’s Firozabad district. They were arrested on Sunday, the police said.

A case was registered and a team was formed to trace the accused.

During investigation, police analysed bank transactions and tracked the money trail, which revealed the use of multiple accounts to layer the proceeds.

“The accused routed the money through various payment gateways and wallets to conceal its origin,” the officer said, adding that two mobile phones used in the crime have been recovered. Further investigation is underway.

Traffic curbs likely in central Delhi for IPL match on Apr 8: Cops

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Traffic movement in central Delhi is likely to be affected on April 8 in view of the Indian Premier League (IPL) match at the Arun Jaitley Stadium, police said.

According to an advisory issued by the Delhi Traffic Police, congestion is expected on key stretches around the stadium from 12 pm to midnight, with the match between the Delhi Capitals and Gujarat Titans scheduled between 7 pm and 10.30 pm. The advisory said that, depending on traffic conditions, diversions and restrictions may be imposed on Bahadur Shah Zafar Marg and JLN Marg during the day.

Final hurdle cleared for ITPO underpass

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Ending years of delay, the long-pending ITPO Tunnel-Underpass-5 at Pragati Maidan has received final clearance from Indian Railways, putting the crucial infrastructure project back on track for completion by December 2026.

The underpass, a key link in Delhi’s central traffic network, had remained stalled due to technical challenges and lack of inter-agency coordination, despite substantial public investment. Officials said the clearance resolves the final hurdle, enabling full-scale execution.

A major breakthrough had earlier come in August 2025, when the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs approved a revised execution plan addressing issues such as soil settlement and structural safety near the railway embankment. The

plan included measures like foundation stabilisation, structural stitching and adoption of a revised construction methodology. However, the absence of Railways’ approval had continued to stall progress. The issue was taken up by PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh Verma, who held multiple meetings with railway authorities and conducted site visits to resolve pending concerns.

Speaking on the development, Verma said, “This project had been stuck for years due to pending clearances and lack of coordination. ... With this NOC, the final hurdle has been cleared. The focus now is on execution, speed, and accountability.”

Once completed, the underpass is expected to ease congestion around Pragati Maidan and the ITO corridor, improving connectivity and traffic flow in the area.

Delhi conducts EWS, CWSN admission draw for 2026–27

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government on Monday conducted a computerised draw of lots for admissions under the EWS/DG and Children With Special Needs (CWSN) categories for the 2026–27 academic session, with Education Minister Ashish Sood asserting that the process was “fair, transparent and technology-driven.”

The draw, organised by the Directorate of Education at the Old Secretariat, covered entry-level classes (Nursery, KG and Class 1) in private unaided recognised schools. It was conducted in the presence of parents and stakeholders to ensure transparency.

Addressing the media, Sood said, “The Delhi Government is committed to ensure that every eligible child in Delhi gets access to quality education through a fair and transparent



process.” He added that technological interventions, including “NIC-developed software and Aadhaar-based verification (encrypted Aadhaar seeding),” have helped eliminate duplicate and erroneous applications, ensuring “better opportunities for genuine beneficiaries.”

The minister highlighted a significant increase in seats this year. The total number of schools has risen from 2,219 to 2,308, while EWS/DG seats have increased from 44,045 to 48,092 and CWSN seats from

6,471 to 7,609. Overall seats have gone up to 55,701, marking an increase of 5,185 seats.

According to official data, the Directorate received 1,39,524 applications this year, with 1,38,536 complete applications under EWS/DG and 988 under the CWSN category.

Sood contrasted the figures with 2024–25 under the Aam Aadmi Party government, stating, “A total of 2,40,084 applications were received, out of which more than one lakh were duplicate and fake.” He claimed that “approximately 75% were extra compared to genuine applications.” He said applications declined as government schools improved, with CM Shri Schools boosting parental trust. Sood added that once results are frozen, no changes are allowed, and the next admission stage will begin within three days for a smooth process.

SANJAY VAN ON APR 11

DDA plans nature and heritage walk

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) will organise a heritage walk at Sanjay Van in South Delhi on April 11, aimed at promoting awareness about the ecological and historical significance of the Southern Ridge. The initiative is being conducted in collaboration with the School of Heritage Research and Management (SHRM).

According to officials, the walk, titled “Sanjay Van: Where Nature Meets History,” will take participants through lesser-known trails of the ridge, highlighting its rich biodiversity and hidden historical remnants. The event is scheduled from 9:30 a.m. to 11:00 a.m., with the meeting point at Gate No. 3 of Sanjay Van.

The Southern Ridge, part of the Aravalli range, plays a crucial role in maintaining Delhi’s ecological balance, acting as a green lung for the city. Over the years, it has also been home to several heritage structures and ruins, many of which remain unexplored by the public.

Officials said the initiative seeks to encourage citizens to engage with Delhi’s natural and cultural heritage while fostering environmental consciousness. Participants have been invited to register through a QR code provided by the organisers.

The DDA has been actively promoting green initiatives and public engagement programmes, with events such as heritage walks aimed at reconnecting residents with the city’s ecological assets.

APPLICATIONS OPEN TILL APRIL 30

Delhi govt invites applications of SC, ST, OBC students for 2025–26 scholarships

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government on Monday invited applications for scholarships from SC, ST and OBC categories students for the academic year 2025-26, according to an official notice.

The notice said five state-funded schemes and several centrally sponsored schemes are open for eligible students studying in schools, colleges and universities in Delhi. The last date for submission of applications is April 30 and applications can be submitted through the e-district portal.

Among the key schemes, the government is offering

Govt is offering tuition and compulsory fee reimbursement for the students of the three categories in Classes 1 to 12

reimbursement of tuition and other compulsory fees for the students of the three categories studying in Classes 1 to 12 in recognised schools in Delhi. The benefit is available to students from families with an annual income of up to Rs 3 lakh, subject to academic performance and attendance conditions, it said.

It further mentioned that a merit scholarship scheme has also been announced for SC/ST/OBC students enrolled

in professional, technical and higher education courses. Financial assistance under this scheme ranges from Rs 8,000 to Rs 24,000 per annum depending on the level of study and whether the student is a hosteller or a day scholar. Students must have secured at least 60 per cent marks in the previous academic year to be eligible.

In addition, the government will award Rs 25,000 to toppers from these categories under the Dr B R Ambedkar

State Topper Award in each discipline across universities, the department said.

The ‘Mukhyamantri Vidyarthi Pratibha Yojana’ will provide annual assistance of Rs 5,000 for students in Classes 9 and 10 and Rs 10,000 for those in Classes 11 and 12, subject to income and academic criteria, it read. The department is also offering financial assistance to SC students for pursuing higher studies abroad at the master’s and PhD levels, it said.

Selected candidates can receive up to Rs 5 lakh annually, with caps for higher studies, as schemes aim to support disadvantaged students and improve access to education.

CM pushes time-bound execution of projects, mandates monitoring via Pragati Portal

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Emphasising speed and accountability in governance, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Monday directed all departments to ensure time-bound completion of development works, with strict monitoring through the CM Pragati Portal.

Chairing a high-level review meeting at the Delhi Secretariat with administrative secretaries and heads of departments, the Chief Minister reviewed progress on projects announced in the 2026–27 Budget. She stressed that achieving the vision of a ‘Viksit Delhi’ would require efficient execution and visible outcomes.

Gupta said timely implementation is critical and instructed departments to upload regular updates on the Pragati Portal, including project timelines and milestones, to enable real-time tracking. Chief Secretary Rajeev Verma was also present at the meeting.

Highlighting accountabil-

CM Gupta underlined that all stages of projects, from tendering to completion, must follow a strict timeline

ity, the Chief Minister asked officials to set clear short-term targets of 15 days, 20 days and one month, ensuring continuous monitoring and early identification of delays. She underlined that all stages of projects—from tendering to completion—must follow a strict timeline, and any bottlenecks should be escalated immediately.

Gupta called for stronger inter-department coordination, directing parallel execution of projects to avoid delays. She stressed optimal use of budgetary resources and a target-driven approach. Setting a 2029 deadline, she urged efficient execution and greater utilisation of Central schemes to accelerate development.

Gupta meets sanitation workers, promises action on safety, wages, dignity



OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In a direct outreach to ground-level workforce, Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Monday held an interaction with sanitation workers’ unions, assuring swift action on long-pending issues related to safety, wages and working conditions.

The meeting, held at the Chief Minister’s Jan Seva Sadan, brought together members of the core committee of sanitation workers’ unions from the Municipal Corporation of Delhi. Representatives flagged key concerns including recruitment, regularisation, wage delays, workplace safety and overall service conditions.

During the discussion, union members also demanded improved healthcare facilities, permanent employment and a more dignified working environment, citing the challenging nature of sanitation work.

Addressing the gathering, Gupta acknowledged the critical role played by sanitation workers in maintaining the city’s cleanliness and functioning. She said, “Sanitation

workers play a crucial role in keeping the city clean and functional, and protecting their interests remains a top priority for the government.”

Assuring full support, she added, “The Delhi government stands firmly with them,” while emphasising that the administration is committed to addressing their concerns in a time-bound manner.

Taking cognisance of the issues raised, the Chief Minister directed concerned departments to conduct a detailed review and initiate prompt action. She stressed that the government will ensure that workers receive better working conditions, enhanced safety measures and the dignity they deserve.

Gupta said the government is committed to taking concrete steps to address issues, prioritising sanitation workers’ rights and improving their quality of life. The interaction is part of efforts to strengthen engagement with frontline workers, address grassroots concerns through dialogue, and reinforce a focus on welfare and inclusive governance.

ED FLAGS IBC IRREGULARITIES

CBI claims over Rs 73,000 crore bank ‘fraud’ in Anil Ambani Group probe

MPPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) is probing bank loan frauds cumulatively worth Rs 73,000 crore in seven cases registered against the Reliance Anil Ambani Group, according to a status report filed in the Supreme Court in February.

The CBI informed the court that it is actively investigating seven cases, and is probing the roles of certain public servants as well. After reviewing the status report filed by the CBI and its financial investigations counterpart, the Enforcement Directorate (ED), the apex court issued an order on March 23. “...the losses in the other cases also come to several thousands of crores, totalling lakhs of approximately Rs 73,006 crore,” the apex court order said, referring to the CBI probe.

A response from the Reli-



REPRESENTATIVE PIC

ance Group to a query sent by regarding this development is awaited. The ED told the court that it seized certain documents that speak about a purported “Project Help”, indicating that insolvency proceedings were “deliberately” started through unrelated lenders. “According to the report, all funding for IBC (insolvency and bankruptcy code) acquisitions was arranged through a

group of eight NBFCs (non-banking financial companies) ... It is noted that claims totalling approximately Rs 2,983 crore were settled for Rs 26 crore,” the SC said, after perusing the ED report.

The ED also informed the court that it has constituted a special investigation team to probe these cases and is currently working on eight cases related to the Reliance Anil

Ambani Group (RAAG).

The Supreme Court said, “Since the preliminary facts speak for themselves, it is a situation where senior officials of the investigating agencies must collaborate and make a strong effort to uncover any irregularities, illegal acts, or collusion and connivance by public officials, especially those in the financial institutions, if any, in granting undue benefits to the manage-

ment of RAAG.”

“While we do not express any opinion on the merits of the allegations, all that we wish to observe is that it is imperative upon the CBI and the ED to complete the investigation in a most dispassionate, fair, transparent and independent manner and take the ongoing investigation to its logical conclusion in a time-bound manner,” it added.

The ED also informed the three-member Supreme Court bench led by Chief Justice Surya Kant that it has “not received” certain information sought from sister probe agencies concerning this investigation.

The court directed that all agencies and financial institutions shall extend their “full cooperation” to the ED and make the necessary information available in a timely fashion. It has scheduled the next hearing for April 30.

HIGHLIGHTS

» According to a status report filed by the CBI in the SC in February, it is actively investigating seven cases, and is probing the roles of certain public servants as well

» The ED also informed the court that it has constituted a special investigation team to probe these cases

» The Enforcement Directorate is currently working on eight cases related to the Reliance Anil Ambani Group (RAAG)

CCTVs in police stations: SC asks Home Secy to appear today

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court has asked the Union home secretary to remain present before it on Tuesday so that appropriate assistance could be drawn from him in implementation of the scheme for installation of CCTVs in police stations.

A bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta on Monday passed the order while hearing a suo motu case over lack of functional CCTVs in police stations.

During the hearing, the bench asked the counsel appearing for the Centre about a recent media report over removal of CCTV cameras made by a Chinese firm which are installed at several places citing security issue.

Referring to the report, Justice Mehta said the Centre itself has given instructions to take down the cameras taken from a neighbouring country because they are capturing data and sending it there.

“Now, the government has issued instructions to remove particular cameras,” the bench



observed.

Additional Solicitor General Raja Thakare, appearing for the Centre, said no formal order has yet been passed in this regard.

Senior advocate Siddhartha Dave, who is assisting the top court as an amicus curiae in the matter, told the bench that most of the states have done installation of CCTVs and they are in the process of setting up centralised dashboards.

When Dave said that Kerala has the best set up, Justice Nath said, “If you say that Kerala has to best set up, why can’t it be followed up by other states?”

The bench said this should be discussed by the authorities.

Thakare said 60 per cent funding is by the Centre.

The bench was informed that an under secretary level

officer had attended the meeting which was held to deliberate upon the feasibility, modalities and implementation framework of the issues flagged in the orders passed by the apex court earlier.

The bench expressed its dissatisfaction and told Thakare, “We are passing orders and you are sending an under secretary level officer to attend the meeting?”

The law officer assured the court that a high-level official would attend the meeting.

“Let this matter come up tomorrow again. The home secretary, Union of India, to remain present before this court so that appropriate assistance can be drawn from him in implementation of the scheme that is being monitored by this court,” the bench said.

On February 26, the apex court directed the Centre and others to participate in a meeting to deliberate upon the feasibility, modalities and implementation framework of the issues, including creation of a centralised dashboard and standardisation of CCTV infrastructure in police stations.

From Page 1 Tehran rejects

under “very, very heavy enemy fire,” with one helicopter returning riddled with bullets.

He also threatened to jail the journalist who first reported that US forces were searching for the F-15 weapons officer if they don’t reveal their sources.

“The person that did the story will go to jail if he doesn’t say, and that doesn’t last long,” Trump said.

Trump didn’t name the journalist or news organisation. He said the leak tipped off the Iranians, endangering the officer and his rescuers. He called the leaker “a sick person.”

Earlier, Trump said he was “very upset” with Iran and warned that Tehran is “going to pay a big price” if it fails to reach a deal, signalling a hardening stance as his self-imposed deadline approaches.

Speaking to reporters outside the White House, Trump made it clear that the Tuesday deadline for Iran to agree to terms is final. “It could end very quickly if they do what they have to do,” Trump said. “They have to do certain things. They know that.” He added that “the people there now are much more reasonable than the lunatics that you had in phase 1 and phase 2.”

Trump said the US has “many alternatives” as the conflict continues, but hinted he is not ready to step back just yet. He said Washington could “leave right now” and that it would take Iran years to recover, but added that he wants to “finish it up.”

He also reiterated that “Iran cannot have a nuclear weapon”, a claim Tehran has repeatedly denied, insisting its nuclear programme is not aimed at developing weapons.

Trump wants Tehran to open the Strait of Hormuz or see its power plants and bridges attacked. Ferdousi Pour said Iranian and Omani officials were working on a mechanism for administering the shipping chokepoint.

The rejection came as Israel struck a key petrochemical plant in the massive South Pars natural gas field and killed two paramilitary Revolutionary Guard commanders.

The gas field attack aimed at eliminating a major source of revenue for Iran, Israel said. The field is critical to electricity production, but the strike appeared to be separate from Trump’s threats to target power plants and bridges if Tehran doesn’t reopen the Strait of Hormuz to all shipping traffic by Monday night Washington time.

Iran’s grip on the strait has caused oil prices to surge and shaken the world economy.

Israel’s Defence Minister Israel Katz called the plant Iran’s largest petrochemical facility. The gas field shared with Qatar is the world’s largest. Iranian state media blamed the US and Israel for the attack.

After Israel’s attack on South Pars in March, Trump said Israel would not attack it again but warned that if Iran continued striking Qatar’s energy infrastructure, the US would “massively blow up” the field.

Egyptian, Pakistani and Turkish mediators have sent Iranian

Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi and US Mideast envoy Steve Witkoff a proposal calling for a 45-day ceasefire and the reopening of the strait, two Mideast officials told AP.

Iran’s foreign ministry spokesman Esmail Baghaei earlier told journalists that messages were being exchanged with mediators but “negotiations are entirely incompatible with ultimatums, crimes and threats of war crimes.”

In Islamabad, two senior officials said Pakistan’s ceasefire efforts are at an advanced stage but “several spoilers and detractors” are trying to sow confusion. The officials spoke on condition of anonymity because they were not authorized to speak publicly about the talks.

Meanwhile, explosions boomed in Tehran and low-flying jets could be heard for hours. Among those killed was the head of intelligence for Iran’s paramilitary Revolutionary Guard, Maj Gen Majid Khademi, according to Iranian state media and Israel’s defense minister. Israel said it also killed the leader of the Revolutionary Guard’s undercover unit in its expeditionary Quds Force, Asghar Bakari.

Israel’s defence minister vowed to keep targeting top-ranking officials. Israel’s military later said it struck three Tehran airports overnight — Bahram, Mehrabad and Azmayesh — hitting dozens of helicopters and aircraft it said belonged to the Iranian Air Force.

Separately, Kuwait, the United Arab Emirates and Saudi Arabia activated air defences to intercept Iranian missiles and drones. Tehran has kept up pressure on Gulf neighbours, which has included strikes against infrastructure like oil fields. In Israel, Iranian missiles hit the northern city of Haifa, where four people from one family were found dead in the rubble of a residential building.

Iran’s attacks on regional energy infrastructure and its hold on the Strait of Hormuz, through which a fifth of the world’s oil is shipped in peacetime, have sent global energy prices soaring.

Brent crude oil, the international standard, rose to USD 109 in early Monday spot trading, about 50 per cent higher than when the war started, then wavered. US stocks were mostly holding steady.

Thick smoke rose near Tehran’s Azadi Square after an airstrike hit the grounds of the Sharif University of Technology.

Iranian media reported damage to buildings and a natural gas distribution site next to campus. The university is empty as the war has forced all schools into online classes.

A strike near Eslamshar, southwest of Tehran, killed at least 15 people, authorities said.

Bengal SIR

an inclusion rate of 55 per cent (around 24 lakh), while roughly 45 per cent—about 20 lakh—were excluded. He added that around seven lakh appeals have been filed, with several lakh more expected, even as appellate tribunals are yet to be fully operational.

Divan urged publication of a supplementary roll after appeals. Senior Advocate Kapil Sibal sought interim protection for those wrongly excluded, but the court declined both requests and

refused to set any deadline for appellate tribunals.

Justice Bagchi said the rolls must be frozen ahead of elections, cautioning that timelines for tribunals handling lakhs of appeals could create “chaos”. The electoral roll for the first phase polling will freeze on April 6, and for the second phase on April 9.

The court noted that 19 appellate tribunals, comprising former chief justices and judges, are in place and left procedural aspects to them. It directed the Chief Justice of the High Court to form a three-member panel of former senior judges to ensure uniform procedure.

The Bench flagged issues, including delays in real-time e-signature uploads and improper document uploads, noting all eight lakh objections in Malda had been cleared. It directed the portal be kept open till April 7 for e-signatures.

It said grievances, such as the absence of reasons for rejection, can be raised before tribunals, which will examine records independently. A plea by Senior Advocate Kalyan Bandopadhyay to allow those cleared by April 21 to vote was declined.

The court also directed that receipts be issued for physical appeals by district magistrates and sub-divisional officers.

On honorarium, it asked the Chief Justice to collect bank details of former judges heading tribunals and ensure timely payment.

The next hearing is scheduled on April 13.

Meanwhile, the court was told that an 88-year-old grandson of painter Nandalal Bose was excluded from the rolls. Senior Advocate Jaideep Gupta raised the issue, after which the tribunal was asked to decide it expeditiously.

Parl rejects

The Speaker, after examining the submission, rejected the plea. The notification stated that the decision followed “a careful and objective assessment of all relevant aspects and issues involved”.

The rejection of the notices halts, at this stage, the opposition’s attempt to initiate proceedings against the Chief Election Commissioner.

Under the constitutional framework, the removal of a Chief Election Commissioner follows a process similar to that of a judge of the Supreme Court or a High Court. Such a step requires proof of “misbehaviour or incapacity” and must meet a high threshold in Parliament.

The developments come amid heightened political tensions over electoral processes, with opposition parties continuing to question the conduct of the Election Commission and its handling of voter roll revisions.

PM highlights

construction of the new Parliament building, the introduction of 10 per cent reservation for economically weaker sections in the general category, the ban on triple talaq, the Citizenship Amendment Act, and the construction of the Ram temple in Ayodhya. He also pointed to the 2019 abrogation of Article 370,

which ended the special status of Jammu and Kashmir, calling it the fulfilment of a long-standing commitment.

Modi said the BJP-led government continues to address issues such as corruption, infiltration, demographic changes, and dynastic politics, while also working to remove what he described as remnants of a colonial mindset. He asserted that technological upgrades in border security, development of border villages, and efforts to curb Naxalism were part of a broader national security strategy.

On foreign policy, Modi referred to the ongoing West Asia conflict and reiterated India’s belief in “Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam,” or the world as one family. He said India had moved from maintaining equidistance to building closer ties with multiple countries simultaneously.

Marking 25 years of the National Democratic Alliance, Modi described it as a coalition focused on governance and public welfare, citing its expansion as evidence of inclusivity and its responsiveness to regional aspirations. He contrasted this with what he called dynastic politics and Left governance models, stating that the BJP’s approach was based on stability and service.

In a message posted earlier on social media, Modi extended greetings to party workers and credited their efforts for the BJP’s growth since its founding on April 6, 1980. He said the party remains committed to the vision of a developed India, with governance centred on public welfare and long-term progress.

Delhi Assembly

raised concerns about possible explosives. Bomb disposal squads and multiple police teams carried out a thorough search of the premises, while forensic experts examined the objects. No suspicious material was found.

“It is too early to comment on the motive behind the entire incident. Our teams are questioning him. Motive is not clear. But we are investigating the entire matter from every possible angle,” a police officer said, adding that the development comes amid recent bomb threats targeting the Assembly.

The suspect vehicle remained inside the premises for nearly five minutes. “The entire incident happened very quickly, in just five to seven minutes,” the officer added.

Deputy Director (Media) to the Speaker, Kanchan Azad, said the breach raised concerns about security arrangements. He noted that Gate No. 1, typically reserved for VIP access during special events, is not regularly used and has lighter deployment when the House is not in session. Only one CRPF personnel was stationed there at the time, sources said.

Police, however, stated that the Assembly complex has four gates, with Gate No. 1 serving as the main entrance where most personnel are deployed. On a daily basis, around 22 CRPF personnel and 70 to 80 police officers are assigned to the site.

Following the incident, alerts were issued across Delhi and neighbouring states. The vehicle was intercepted near a Roop Nagar police picket, where officers detained the driver as he attempted to escape at high speed. Two others were also taken into custody from north Delhi, and the car was seized. Senior officers, including Delhi Police Chief Satish Golchha and Special Commissioner Ravindra Yadav, visited the site. CCTV footage is being reviewed to reconstruct the sequence of events. Further investigation is ongoing.

Sathankulam

In addition to the death sentences, the court imposed a total fine of Rs 1.40 crore on the convicts, directing that the amount be paid as compensation to the victims’ family.

While delivering the sentence, the judge observed that the police are meant to safeguard citizens, and when they themselves become perpetrators of violence, strict punishment is necessary to deter such acts. The court also noted that the simultaneous killing of both father and son had destroyed the foundation of an entire family.

The investigation, which followed intervention by the Madurai Bench of the Madras High Court and was later handed over to the CBI, involved the examination of 105 witnesses over five years.

SC declines

proceedings expeditiously. It added that if arguments are not completed on the scheduled date, the hearing should continue on the next working day.

The court noted that the appellant’s interests were adequately protected and that no further directions were necessary. “If the monitoring committee decides to take any major policy decision, they will take leave of the NCLAT,” the bench stated.

Senior advocate Kapil Sibal, appearing for Vedanta, argued that the company had submitted a higher offer and questioned the approval of Adani’s plan. “If this plan is implemented, then you see what the creditors get. My number is Rs 17,926.21 crore. They are paying 14,000-odd crore. Creditors will get more,” he said, adding that Vedanta’s bid offered better value in terms of net present value and total payout. However, Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, representing the committee of creditors, countered that the difference between the bids was around Rs 500 crore and that other factors were also considered.

The dispute stems from the National Company Law Tribunal’s March 17 order approving Adani Enterprises’ bid. Vedanta challenged the decision before the NCLAT, which on March 24 declined to stay the implementation but agreed to hear the matter on April 10. Vedanta subsequently approached the Supreme Court on March 25.

Vedanta has filed two appeals before the NCLAT, questioning both the validity of the resolu-

tion plan and its approval by the committee of creditors and the NCLT.

JAL entered the Corporate Insolvency Resolution Process in June 2024 after defaulting on loans worth Rs 57,185 crore. The company holds a wide portfolio of assets, including real estate projects such as Jaypee Greens in Greater Noida and Wishtown in Noida, as well as the Jaypee International Sports City near the upcoming Jewar airport.

It also operates five hotels across NCR, Mussoorie and Agra, owns four cement plants in Uttar Pradesh and Madhya Pradesh, and has interests in subsidiaries including Jaiprakash Power Ventures Ltd and Yamuna Expressway Tolling Ltd.

Adani’s bid received 89 per cent of creditor votes in November, ahead of Vedanta and Dalmia Bharat, with lenders favouring its offer of around Rs 6,000 crore upfront and a faster repayment schedule of two years compared to Vedanta’s five-year timeline.

SC orders CBI

affidavit submitted by the state government to argue that several contracts were granted to these entities. The state government had earlier described the plea as “sponsored litigation”.

The court had reserved its verdict on February 17 after hearing arguments and had previously, on December 2, asked the state to provide a comprehensive affidavit detailing all contracts awarded between 2015 and 2025, including those linked to the chief minister’s relatives. Pema Khandu, along with his father Dorjee Khandu’s second wife Rinchin Drema and his nephew Tsering Tashi, were made parties to the case. The petition specifically alleged that Drema’s firm, Brand Eagles, secured numerous contracts despite an apparent conflict of interest. In its observations, the bench underlined that the State acts as a trustee of public resources and is bound by constitutional principles of fairness and transparency. “The State does not hold public resources as a private proprietor but as a trustee on behalf of the people,” the court said, adding that allocation of contracts and execution of public works must adhere to Article 14 of the Constitution, which guarantees equality.

The court noted that public confidence depends on governance systems that operate with integrity and accountability. It said allegations of nepotism, patronage or opaque decision-making in the distribution of public resources raise concerns that go beyond administrative lapses and touch upon constitutional values.

Referring to the material placed on record, the bench pointed to audit findings and submissions that indicated repeated use of non-tender methods, lack of documented reasons for such decisions and absence of key records such as vouchers and tender documents in several high-value projects. It observed that the state had not denied extensive use of the work order system and that its responses failed to adequately address the seriousness of the

allegations.

The court reiterated that transferring an investigation to the CBI is reserved for rare and exceptional cases, particularly where high public officials are involved or where an independent probe is necessary to ensure credibility. It said the present case met the threshold for such intervention, citing concerns about the integrity of public procurement and the need to maintain public trust in the rule of law.

Artemis II

mission specialist Christina Koch, along with Canadian astronaut Jeremy Hansen.

The spacecraft passed within approximately 4,070 miles of the moon, executing a precise loop before beginning its return trajectory toward Earth. The mission is expected to conclude with a Pacific Ocean splashdown on Friday, following a four-day journey home.

Artemis II is following a free-return trajectory, the same path used during Apollo 13 after an onboard oxygen tank explosion forced NASA to abandon its planned landing. This route uses the gravitational pull of Earth and the moon to guide the spacecraft in a figure-eight pattern, allowing it to return safely without requiring major propulsion changes.

During the flyby, the astronauts carried out a series of observations and imaging tasks. Among their key targets was the Orientale Basin, a vast impact formation stretching nearly 600 miles across and known for its distinct ringed structure. The crew also observed the sites of Apollo 12 and Apollo 14 landings, along with portions of the moon’s south polar region, where future missions aim to send astronauts.

The timing of the mission also allowed the crew to witness a rare celestial alignment. Having launched last Wednesday, Artemis II was positioned to observe a total solar eclipse from behind the moon, offering a unique vantage point of the sun, Earth and lunar surface. The astronauts have also reported views of Mercury, Venus, Mars and Saturn, alongside a distant perspective of Earth. NASA geologist Kelsey Young, who trained the crew in lunar geology, said the mission is expected to generate thousands of images. “People all over the world connect with the moon. This is something that every single person on this planet can understand and connect with,” she said ahead of the flyby.

For the astronauts, the mission also carries a broader human perspective. Glover, reflecting during Christianity’s Holy Week, described Earth as “an oasis” in the vastness of space. “This is an opportunity for us to remember where we are, who we are, and that we are the same thing and that we’ve got to get through this together,” he said.

Artemis II is a key step in NASA’s long-term lunar plans. Artemis III is expected to test docking procedures in lunar orbit, while Artemis IV aims to land astronauts near the moon’s south pole by 2028, advancing efforts to establish a sustained human presence beyond Earth.



—‘THIS PAK CONNECTION ALWAYS WEIGHS HEAVILY ON COUNTRY’—

Congress keeps singing to Pakistan’s tunes: PM Modi

MPOST BUREAU

BHABANIPUR-SORBHOG/HOJAI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Monday said while his government carried out ‘Operation Sindoor’ on terror camps in Pakistan, the Congress continued to “sing to the tune of” the neighbouring country.

Addressing an election rally in Assam’s Bapeta district, he also accused the Opposition party of taking a myopic view on development, while asserting that the BJP focuses on long-term growth.

“The party always took short-term measures so that they could indulge in corruption. But the BJP looks far ahead while taking decisions for all-around development of all sections of society,” Modi said.

Modi alleged that during the 2016 surgical strikes or the 2025 ‘Operation Sindoor’, the Congress has always sung to Pakistan’s tune, giving importance to their agenda.

“This Pakistan connection always weighs heavily on the country (‘hamesha desh par bhari parta hain’), and we can never allow that,” he said.



PM Narendra Modi during a public meeting ahead of the Assam Assembly elections, in Dibrugarh, Assam

Modi also accused the grand old party of neglecting the Army by refusing to implement the ‘One Rank, One Pension’ for the veterans for decades. But the BJP government ensured that justice was done to those who protect the nation by giving them this benefit, he said.

“We have so far disbursed Rs 1.24 lakh-crore to the bank accounts of former Army personnel,” the prime minister said.

Addressing another rally in Hojai, Modi accused the Gandhi family of indulging in dynastic politics and corruption.

“The first family of Congress is the most corrupt in the country, indulging in scams of huge proportions and is currently out on bail,” he said.

The Congress can do only two things -- tell lies and indulge in corruption, he added.

In an apparent swipe at Rahul Gandhi’s “mohabbat ki dukaan” remark, Modi said the Congress represents “mithya ki dukaan” (shop of lies) and “apmaan” (insult).

“There is another family in Assam ... and both are making false promises ahead of the polls,” he said, in an apparent reference to Congress leader

Highlights

» Modi also accused the grand old party of neglecting the Army by refusing to implement the ‘One Rank, One Pension’ for the veterans for decades

» Modi accused the Gandhi family of indulging in dynastic politics and corruption

Gaurav Gogoi.

“The Congress is in power in Himachal, Karnataka and Telangana...they made tall promises before the polls, but what have they done so far?” he asked.

Modi urged people not to be taken in by the Congress’ false promises in Assam and vote for the BJP for a third successive term so that the journey of development can continue.

Referring to the global situation due to conflicts in West Asia, he said the government is working to shield citizens, especially the poor, middle class and farmers, from its impact.

—RULING PARTY RELEASES PROGRESS REPORT—

Kerala polls: LDF claims 97% of 2021 promises fulfilled

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KANNUR: As the Kerala Assembly polls campaign enters its final phase, the ruling LDF on Monday released its progress report, with Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan claiming that around 97 per cent of the promises made in 2021 have been fulfilled.

Releasing the report at a press conference here, Vijayan said that people have the right to know the extent to which election promises have been implemented.

Respecting that right, the LDF government has, since 2016, presented an annual progress report to the public.

“We believe that providing an account as a government is a responsibility. This report briefly summarises the progress of the fifth year of the government that assumed office in 2021,” he said.

Vijayan, who leads the LDF campaign for the April 9 polls, stated that in 2021, 900 promises were placed before the people in the manifesto.

“Of these, approximately 97 per cent of the promises have already been fulfilled or have reached an effective stage of implementation,” he added.



Pinarayi Vijayan

Kerala will go to the polls for 140 Assembly constituencies.

The veteran CPI(M) leader said that to make the common person’s dream of land and housing a reality, five lakh houses have been completed through the LIFE Mission.

“Through this, secure housing has been ensured for lakhs of families,” he added.

Vijayan said the government had focused on improving the lives of ordinary people, especially those who lacked basic facilities.

“We have worked to ensure that development reaches everyone, not just a few,” he said.

The government also distributed land titles to over 4.5 lakh families in the past decade, helping many landless people secure ownership.

According to the CM, long-standing land issues in hilly regions like Idukki have also been resolved.

The chief minister said Kerala has made significant progress in reducing extreme poverty.

“More than 64,000 families have been lifted out of extreme poverty. Kerala has moved towards becoming free from extreme poverty, which is a rare achievement,” he said.

Vijayan also pointed out that no other state in India has undertaken similar steps at this scale.

He said that to protect vulnerable families, the government introduced a law to prevent the seizure of their only homes.

“Financial support has also been extended to women, with over 16 lakh beneficiaries receiving monthly assistance. Welfare measures for the elderly and children in orphanages have also been strengthened,” the CM said.

On the economic front, Vijayan stated that Kerala has created a more business-friendly environment, helping the state secure a top position in ease of doing business rankings.

TN CM Stalin calls for full statehood for Puducherry

PUDUCHERRY: Tamil Nadu Chief Minister and DMK president M K Stalin on Monday alleged that the Centre has shown no interest in granting full statehood to Puducherry, despite the union territory’s legislative Assembly passing resolutions 14 times urging such a move.

Addressing a rally here and formally introducing candidates fielded by the Congress, DMK, and VCK for the April 9 polls, Stalin accused the Lieutenant

Governor of being “all in all” while Chief Minister N Rangasamy is “kept as a puppet chief minister.”

“The forthcoming polls on April 9 are an excellent opportunity for the people to end the current ills in Puducherry, even while it remains a union territory,” he said. Stalin recalled that PM Modi had promised during the last Assembly elections that Puducherry would become the “best Puducherry.”

‘Govt’s handling of LPG crisis is like it dealt with Covid pandemic’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Monday alleged that Prime Minister Narendra Modi has dealt with the “LPG gas crisis” just like it handled the COVID-19 pandemic as it is “devoid of policy, full of grand announcements,” and places the “entire burden” upon the poor.

The Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha asked why it is always the poor who perish first in every crisis and urged people to not remain silent.

“Modi Ji had said: ‘We will handle the LPG gas crisis just like we handled COVID. And indeed, that is exactly what he did. Precisely like COVID - devoid of policy, full of grand announcements, and placing the entire burden upon the poor,” Gandhi said in a post in Hindi on X.

For migrant labourers earning a daily wage of Rs 500-800, cooking gas has become completely unaffordable, he said.

A labourer returning home at night does not even have the money to light the stove, he said.

Rahul asked why it is always the poor who perish first in every crisis and urged people to not remain silent

“The result? Abandon the city; flee back to the village. The very labourers who serve as the backbone of textile mills and factories are today on the verge of breaking down themselves,” he alleged.

“The textile sector is already in the ICU. The manufacturing sector is gasping for breath. And where did this crisis originate? From that diplomatic blunder - committed at the negotiating table - which the government refuses to acknowledge to this day,” Gandhi said.

When arrogance becomes policy, the economy crumbles, labourers are forced to migrate, industries are ruined, and the entire nation is pushed back by decades, Gandhi said, slamming the Modi government.

“There remains but one

question: Why is it always the poor who perish first in every crisis? Do not remain silent. This is not merely a question for the poor; it is a question for all of us,” the former Congress chief said.

Speaking in Parliament on March 23, Prime Minister Modi had said the difficult global conditions caused by the West Asia conflict are likely to persist for a long time and called upon the nation to remain prepared and united, just as it had stood together during the COVID-19 pandemic.

Kharge: Shah only talks about infiltrators, does not deport them

SILCHAR/SRIBHUMI: Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge on Monday attacked the BJP, especially Union Home Minister Amit Shah, for regularly raising the infiltration issue but not deporting the illegal entrants in large numbers despite being in the government for more than 10 years.

Addressing election rallies in Cachar and Sribhumi districts, he also alleged that the BJP has misused the delimitation exercise in Assam in its bid to win elections.

“When Amit Shah comes here, he only talks about Bangladeshi infiltrators. But the BJP doesn’t drive these infiltrators out; they nurture them. It only plays politics in their name,” he said.

For 10 years, the BJP has been in power at the Centre and in Assam, but it could not remove the infiltrators, the Congress leader said.

He claimed that during the Congress-led UPA government, 88,792 illegal migrants were deported from the country between 2005 and 2013.

“But under Narendra Modi’s rule, only 2,566 people were removed between 2014 and 2019. The BJP, Narendra Modi and Amit Shah just make electoral promises; they do nothing in reality,” the Congress chief alleged.

Kharge also slammed the BJP for allegedly misusing the delimitation exercise in Assam to win the elections. It was carried out in 2023.

During the delimitation exercise, Muslims were removed from areas where they had been in the majority, while other people were added, he alleged.

“In areas where there were more Dalits and Adivasis, people from other classes were included,” he claimed.



Heartiest Greetings
on the Parkash Utsav of
Hind Di Chaadar
Sri Guru Tegh Bahadur Ji

April 7, 2026

“I pay my respects to Sri Guru Tegh Bahadur Ji on the special occasion of his Parkash Purab. He is respected throughout the world for his courage and his efforts to serve the underprivileged.”
- Narendra Modi



Information, Public Relations & Languages Department, Haryana

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MUST ACT AS TRUSTEE ON BEHALF OF PEOPLE

State not proprietor of public resources: SC

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The State does not hold public resources as a “private proprietor” but as a trustee on behalf of the people, the Supreme Court said on Monday.

A bench headed by Justice Vikram Nath said whenever the State undertakes the allocation of public resources, award of public contracts or execution of public works, it is bound to act in a manner that is transparent, fair and consistent with the guarantee of equality under Article 14 of the Constitution.

The top court’s observations came while directing the CBI to register within two weeks a preliminary enquiry into allegations of preferential allotment of contracts for public works in Arunachal Pradesh to firms

allegedly owned or related to family members of Chief Minister Pema Khandu.

The bench, also comprising Justices Sandeep Mehta and N V Anjaria, said public confidence in governance rests upon the assurance that opportunities created by the State are administered through institutions that respect equality, integrity and accountability.

“Where the distribution of public resources is clouded by allegations of nepotism, patronage or opaque decision-making, the issue is not merely one of administrative irregularity. It raises concerns that go to the heart of the constitutional promise that State action shall be fair, impartial and guided by reason,” it said.

The bench said constitutional courts, as guardians

HIGHLIGHTS

- » The top court’s observations came while directing the CBI to register within two weeks a preliminary enquiry into allegations of preferential allotment of contracts for public works in Arunachal to firms allegedly related to family members of CM Pema Khandu



- » It said the award of public contracts is an exercise of public power
- » It involves the expenditure of public funds and the conferment of economic benefit by the State

of that promise, are therefore required to ensure that the exercise of public authority remains anchored in legality, transparency and institutional accountability.

“In a constitutional democracy governed by the rule of

law, the exercise of public power is always subject to constitutional discipline. The State does not hold public resources as a private proprietor, but as a trustee on behalf of the people,” the bench said in its 35-page verdict.

It said the top court’s jurisprudence has consistently emphasised that the power to direct an investigation by the CBI is to be exercised with restraint.

“The governing principle is that the transfer of investigation to the CBI is justified only in rare and exceptional cases where it is necessary to do justice between the parties and to instil confidence in the public mind, or where the investigation by the State police lacks credibility and it is necessary to secure a fair, honest and complete investigation,” the bench said.

It said illustratively, such a transfer may be warranted where high officials of the State are involved, where the accusation is against top officials of the investigating

agency, such that they may influence the course of investigation, or where the probe is prima facie found to be tainted or biased.

The bench said the court ordinarily examines whether the material placed before it discloses a prima facie case raising serious questions of legality; circumstances suggesting that a probe by ordinary State machinery may not inspire confidence where high public functionaries are implicated, and the necessity of an independent inquiry to preserve public confidence in the rule of law.

It said the award of public contracts is an exercise of public power and it involves the expenditure of public funds and the conferment of economic benefit by the State.

Mideast war pushes up ammonia prices, hits UP cold storages

Delays in supply also being reported

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

TAKEAWAYS

- » Ammonia is a key refrigerant used for preserving perishable produce
- » Industry estimates indicate that the price of ammonia has nearly doubled in recent weeks

LUCKNOW: The impact of the ongoing West Asia conflict is now being felt beyond fuel and cooking gas, with a sharp rise in ammonia prices beginning to affect cold storage operations and the agriculture economy in Uttar Pradesh.

Around 2,500 cold storages across the state, from Aligarh to Varanasi, are facing operational stress due to a steep increase in ammonia costs, a key refrigerant used for preserving perishable produce. The situation is likely to hit potato-producing districts the hardest, as storage costs rise significantly.

Industry estimates indicate that the price of ammonia has nearly doubled in recent weeks. A 60 kg cylinder, which earlier cost around Rs 7,200, is now being sold for up to Rs 15,000 in several districts, disrupting cost calculations for cold storage operators.

In Agra, which has 327 cold storages, the sector consumes an average of 1.5 to 2 tonnes of ammonia in a season. Agra Cold Storage Association president Bhuvesh Agarwal said there was a supply crunch around March 20, when prices had surged to Rs 300 to Rs 350 per kg. “Supply has improved now, but prices remain elevated at Rs 100 to Rs 130 per kg compared to the usual Rs 60 to Rs 80,” he said.

Similar trends have been reported from other districts. In Mainpuri, cold storage operator Piyush Chandel said nearly 1,800 kg of ammonia is required per unit in a season, and costs have doubled this year. Firozabad Cold Storage Association president Arun Kumar Chandel said ammonia that was available at Rs 70 per kg last year is now

being purchased at around Rs 140 per kg.

In Kanpur, prices have risen by up to 20 percent, reaching Rs 109 to Rs 110 per kg from the earlier Rs 90 to Rs 95 range. While cold storage rents have not yet been increased, operators say sustained high input costs may force a revision, adding to farmers’ burden.

Delays in supply are also being reported. In Farrukhabad, cold storage owners said ammonia refilling that earlier took 24 hours is now taking up to 48 hours. In Etawah, operators reported prices rising three to four times at one stage, though supply has since stabilised at higher rates.

In Aligarh, the sharp rise has significantly disrupted operational viability. Cold Storage Owners Association president Girraj Godhani said the sector should be treated as an essential agriculture-linked service.

Despite price pressures, supply conditions have improved in several regions. Districts such as Meerut, Saharanpur, Bijnor, Shamli, Muzaffarnagar, Prayagraj and Baghpat currently report adequate availability of ammonia. In Bulandshahr, officials said there have been no complaints of shortages so far, with most operators sourcing ammonia from Delhi.

Govt working to establish AI, digital colleges in state: Haryana CM Saini

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Emphasising the growing role of artificial intelligence in education, Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Monday said the state government is working towards establishing AI and digital colleges to equip youth with future-ready skills.

Saini made the remarks during the convocation ceremony at Deenbandhu Chhotu Ram University of Science and Technology (DCRUST).

Vice President C. P. Radhakrishnan attended the convocation ceremony as chief guest, while Haryana Governor and Chancellor Ashim Kumar Ghosh was also present.

Addressing the gathering, Saini congratulated the graduating students, saying the

degrees and medals were the result of years of hard work, discipline and dedication. He also acknowledged the role of teachers and parents in shaping students’ achievements.

Recalling the legacy of social reformer Deenbandhu Chaudhary Chhotu Ram, after whom the university is named, Saini said education remains the most powerful tool to overcome poverty and ignorance. He noted that the institution continues to contribute to nation-building by blending these ideals with modern science and technology.

Highlighting Haryana’s progress, the Chief Minister said the state has established a strong identity through advancements in education, sports, research, culture and industry. He reiterated the

government’s focus on making youth self-reliant and globally competitive.

To promote research, the state has allocated Rs 20 crore under the Haryana State Research Fund. In 2025–26, over 350 proposals were received, with around 90 shortlisted. An additional Rs 20 crore has been earmarked this year. Alongside, nearly two lakh youth have been provided employment through a transparent recruitment process, he said. Saini added that a Rs 10 crore fund will be created to boost quality higher education and research excellence.

Urging students to remain dedicated, he called for mental, physical and moral strength to succeed in a competitive world.

He extended his best wishes to the graduates.

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Monday directed officials to expedite the disposal of all pending ‘tatima’ cases across the state, stressing that delays lead to repeated visits by citizens, unnecessary disputes and administrative inefficiency.

Chairing a meeting of the District Public Relations and Grievance Redressal Committee in Gurugram, Saini called for a special, time-bound campaign to clear such cases. He said governance must focus on timely relief to citizens and building public trust through prompt action.

A total of 15 complaints were taken up during the meeting, of which 11 were resolved on the spot. Directions were issued to review the remaining four cases in the next meeting,



Haryana CM Nayab Singh Saini chairs the District Public Relations and Grievances Redressal Committee meeting in Gurugram

MPOST

with officials asked to submit status reports.

Saini also reviewed civic issues and directed authorities to improve sanitation and beautification at key locations, including Rezag La Chowk and Shaheed Lieutenant Atul Kataria Chowk. He ordered comprehensive upgrading of the Rezag La Memorial and development of green spaces.

UNNAO RAPE CASE

SC defers hearing on CBI’s plea against relief to Kuldeep Sengar

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Monday flagged off 250 new PRTC buses in Patiala, terming the move a major step towards strengthening public transport.

He said more than 300 additional buses will be inducted into the PRTC fleet in the coming days.

“This will strengthen public transport and also create new employment opportunities for the youth,” Mann said.

Highlighting the corporation’s improved financial health, Mann said PRTC has recorded a 53 per cent rise in gross revenue -- from Rs 607.09 crore in 2021-22 to Rs 927.83 crore in 2024-25.

“In the current financial year 2025-26, the PRTC is expected to cross Rs 950 crore in gross revenue, reflecting

BOOST TO PUBLIC TRANSPORT

Punjab CM flags off 250 new PRTC buses



Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann flags off 250 new PRTC buses in Patiala on Monday

MPOST

ing nearly 57 per cent growth,” he said.

The chief minister further said that since 2022, the PRTC has provided free travel to 34.63 crore women commuters in Punjab for Rs 1,574 crore.

Under the Mukhmantri Tirath Yatra scheme, the PRTC has provided free bus travel facility worth Rs 2.21 crore, enabling 9,529 passengers to

visit religious places within and outside Punjab, he added.

“With the expansion of the bus fleet, people in both urban and rural areas will be able to travel safely and comfortably,” he said.

Detailing development work, Mann said his government has spent around Rs 400 crore across various departments in the Patiala Rural

CLOSER LOOK

» He said more than 300 additional buses will be inducted into the PRTC fleet in the coming days

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QUIET DIGITISATION OF COMMUNITY HEALTHCARE OUTREACH

AAISHA SABIR

NEW DELHI: New Delhi: Artificial intelligence is reshaping India’s approach to frontline healthcare, with policymakers actively backing the shift. Union Minister of State for Science and Technology Jitendra Singh has spoken approvingly of a new generation of AI-based health-tech tools threading their way through the country’s clinical systems.

“With increasing patient and disease load globally, such AI tools help in making patients’ journey to medical care seamless,” Singh told Millennium Post.

Multilingual triage platforms are helping doctors decide faster, hospital waiting rooms are being managed more efficiently, and AI scribing tools now let physicians speak a prescription aloud while software puts it on paper.

What that vision leaves out is where most patients’ journeys actually begin not at a hospital gate, but at a household door in rural India, where a woman arrives on foot, sometimes weeks behind on her incentive payments, carrying a govern-

KEY POINTS

- » Multilingual triage platforms are helping doctors decide faster, hospital waiting rooms are being managed more efficiently, and AI scribing tools now let physicians speak a prescription aloud while software puts it on paper
- » Across several states, AI-powered chatbots running on platforms as ordinary as WhatsApp are being deployed to screen symptoms, guide women through pregnancies, and field the daily health questions the ASHA has traditionally answered in person

ment-issued phone loaded with tracking apps. That woman is the ASHA worker. And it is at her door, without much public announcement, that a parallel digitisation is quietly taking root. Across several states, AI-powered chatbots running on platforms as ordinary as WhatsApp are being deployed to screen symptoms, guide women through pregnancies, and field the daily health questions the ASHA has traditionally answered in person.

“A hybrid model is best suited. I have implemented in my constituency—a real doctor

and an AI platform—are working together to help patients,” Singh explained.

Those building these tools are candid about their pitch. “askNivi complements frontline workers by de-burdening routine tasks while delivering cost-effective, accessible, and anonymous support in regional languages,” said Rubiya Bano, Project Coordinator for askNivi in India. “By combining AI with behavioural science, they are beginning to positively shift health-seeking behaviour at scale.”

If a chatbot handles rou-



- » Shweta Raj, an ASHA worker from Patparganj in Delhi, said that the trouble is that most of her work genuinely requires a human being. She knows which household stopped trusting the local health system after a difficult delivery

tine queries, the logic goes, she is free for work that genuinely requires a human being.

Shweta Raj, an ASHA worker from Patparganj in Delhi, said that the trouble is that most of her work genuinely requires a human being. She knows which household stopped trusting the local health system after a difficult delivery.

“A chatbot cannot notice what goes unsaid,” she said. “It cannot sit with someone until the fear passes. In community health, trust is not a supporting feature. It is the whole architecture,” she added.

RTI DATA EXPOSES ENFORCEMENT GAPS

Agra: Encroachments surge around Taj Mahal & protected monuments

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

INSIGHT

- » Encroachments are spreading rapidly around 154 protected monuments in Agra, including the Taj Mahal, Agra Fort and Fatehpur Sikri
- » RTI data shows that 3,913 illegal constructions have been identified in last 10 years, yet no fines were imposed and no violations have resulted in convictions

AGRA: A sharp rise in illegal constructions around some of India’s most iconic heritage sites has exposed serious enforcement failures, with an RTI disclosure revealing no punitive action over the past decade despite thousands of violations.

Encroachments are spreading rapidly around 154 protected monuments in Agra, including the Taj Mahal, Agra Fort and Fatehpur Sikri. Data obtained under the Right to Information Act shows that 3,913 illegal constructions have been identified in the last 10 years, yet no fines have been imposed and no violations have resulted in convictions.

The Archaeological Survey of India has limited its response to filing police complaints, with little evidence of follow-up action on the ground. This has raised concerns about coordination failures between the ASI, local administration and law enforcement agencies.

Illegal structures have proliferated in sensitive zones, particularly around the eastern gate of the Taj Mahal to Asad Gali.

tombs of Akbar and Mariam, but enforcement on the ground remains ineffective.

Heritage activist Akash Vashistha alleged that authorities are underreporting the scale of the problem. He pointed out that RTI responses from September 2023 and April 2025 recorded the exact same number of violations, suggesting that new encroachments are not being officially documented.

The situation persists despite strict directives from the Supreme Court of India and legal provisions under the Ancient Monuments and Archaeological Sites and Remains Act. Amendments introduced in 2010 required authorities to prepare detailed site plans and regulations for protected monuments, but these measures have yet to be implemented.

Taking a serious view of the issue, the Allahabad High Court has issued notices to both the Centre and the state government while hearing a public interest petition and has sought an explanation for the lack of enforcement.



EDITORIAL
POLLING
PARADOX

India's electoral system has long been regarded as one of the most remarkable democratic exercises in the world. Conducting elections for hundreds of millions of voters across vast and varied geographies is a feat that has earned global admiration. The institutional credibility of the Election Commission, the robustness of electoral rolls, and the peaceful transfer of power have historically reinforced public faith in the process. Yet, beneath this institutional strength, there are emerging signs of stress that can no longer be ignored. The challenge today is not about the mechanics of elections but about their character. The growing influence of money power, the normalisation of competitive populism through freebies, and the sharpening of identity-based mobilisation are raising critical questions about whether electoral integrity is being gradually eroded. The concern is not that democracy is failing, but that it is being reshaped in ways that demand urgent scrutiny.

The role of money in Indian elections has expanded significantly over the years, altering the contours of political competition. While individual candidates are subject to expenditure limits, political parties operate without a clearly enforceable cap, creating an asymmetry that favours those with greater access to financial resources. Estimates by credible organisations such as the Association for Democratic Reforms suggest that recent national elections have ranked among the most expensive globally. The now-scrapped electoral bonds scheme, which allowed anonymous corporate donations, further deepened concerns about opacity and the potential for undue influence in political funding. When financial power becomes a decisive factor in shaping campaigns, outreach, and visibility, it risks distorting the level playing field that elections are meant to ensure. In such a scenario, the line between democratic competition and financial dominance begins to blur, raising uncomfortable questions about the true drivers of electoral success.

Parallel to the rise of money power is the increasing centrality of welfare promises in electoral politics. From cash transfers and subsidised services to targeted benefits for specific voter groups, the language of elections has increasingly shifted towards immediate material gains. It is important to recognise that welfare, in itself, is neither undesirable nor illegitimate. In a country marked by deep socio-economic inequalities, state support remains essential for large sections of the population. However, the timing, scale, and design of such promises often blur the distinction between genuine policy intervention and electoral inducement. The debate around "freebies" is therefore not about denying welfare but about ensuring fiscal prudence and policy credibility. When elections become contests of distribution rather than platforms for long-term economic vision, there is a risk that governance itself becomes short-term and transactional.

Identity politics adds another layer of complexity to this evolving electoral landscape. Appeals based on caste, religion, language, and region have always been part of India's political reality, reflecting the country's social diversity. However, the intensity and centrality of such appeals appear to have sharpened in recent years. Campaign narratives increasingly revolve around issues such as religious identity, migration, and demographic anxieties, often overshadowing developmental concerns. The Model Code of Conduct clearly prohibits appeals that seek to divide voters along communal lines, yet enforcement remains uneven. The rise of digital platforms has further complicated regulation, enabling targeted messaging that can reinforce existing biases and polarisation. As a result, the voter is often addressed not as a citizen with shared interests but as a member of a specific identity group, fragmenting the democratic discourse.

These trends do not operate in isolation; they reinforce each other in ways that can cumulatively influence electoral outcomes. Financial resources enable sustained campaigning, amplify targeted narratives, and support extensive welfare messaging. Identity-based mobilisation, in turn, helps consolidate voter blocs, making electoral strategies more predictable and segmented. The convergence of these factors creates conditions where perception management can overshadow substantive debate. It is important to emphasise that Indian voters have repeatedly demonstrated independence and agency, often defying predictions and political calculations. However, the environment in which choices are made is increasingly shaped by factors that go beyond policy performance and governance record. This raises a deeper concern about whether the spirit of electoral competition is being altered in subtle but significant ways.

The way forward lies not in questioning the legitimacy of elections but in strengthening the safeguards that uphold their integrity. Greater transparency in political funding, stricter disclosure norms, and a re-examination of expenditure frameworks are necessary steps to address the influence of money power. At the same time, there is a need for a more nuanced policy framework that distinguishes between essential welfare and fiscally unsustainable populism. Regulatory institutions must also adapt to the realities of digital campaigning, ensuring that the Model Code of Conduct remains effective in an era of algorithm-driven communication. Ultimately, democracy is not defined solely by the act of voting but by the fairness and credibility of the process that leads to that vote. Preserving that balance is essential if India's electoral model is to remain both resilient and meaningful in the years ahead.

NOBLE
CALLING



AMITABHA CHANDA

THE WRITER IS
A BRAIN AND
SPINE SURGEON,
CURRENTLY THE
DIRECTOR OF
NEUROSURGERY
AT CK BIRLA
HOSPITALS | CMRI,
KOLKATA

Behind the
prestige of
medicine lies a
life of relentless
discipline,
sacrifice and
compassion—
far removed
from common
perceptions of
wealth, ease
and professional
comfort

The profession of medicine, when contemplated in its fullest philosophical and humanitarian dimensions, stands as one of the most exalted vocations known to humankind. It is not merely a career; it is a solemn calling – an austere yet profoundly rewarding path that intertwines knowledge, skill, sacrifice, and compassion. Indeed, such a profession is exceedingly rare, and one may assert without hesitation that it admits of little or no true parallel. At its very core lies the sublime ideal of service to humanity. Even in our present age, countless young men and women continue to dream of donning the mantle of a physician, while their parents, too, nurture this aspiration with quiet pride and hope. Yet, before one sets foot upon this long and demanding journey, it is imperative that certain fundamental truths be clearly apprehended and deeply internalised.

First and foremost, an aspirant to the medical profession must be imbued with an authentic and abiding spirit of service. This does not, by any means, suggest that a physician is expected to renounce rightful remuneration for his or her labour. On the contrary, it is both just and proper that a doctor receives compensation commensurate with the magnitude of responsibility and effort that the profession entails. However, this entitlement must always be harmoniously balanced with an unwavering commitment to patient care, one that is complete, conscientious, and devoid of indifference.

Secondly, the pursuit of medicine demands not only a sound intellectual foundation but, more importantly, a genuine and self-motivated desire to become a doctor. It is not uncommon to encounter individuals who enter this field under the weight of parental expectation or societal pressure. For such individuals, the rigorous course of study soon becomes an ordeal rather than



To become a doctor is to embrace a life defined not by convenience, but by commitment

an opportunity. Even if they succeed in completing the curriculum, they rarely blossom into competent or inspired practitioners.

Thirdly, patience – deep, enduring, and unyielding – is an indispensable virtue in this profession. The study of medicine is not merely prolonged; it is exacting in the extreme. Mastery unfolds slowly, almost imperceptibly, over years of disciplined effort. Unlike several other professions where one may attain stability and recognition within a relatively short span, the medical vocation demands a long gestation period. One must, therefore, cultivate the mental resilience to embrace delay, uncertainty, and sustained endeavour without faltering.

Fourthly, medicine is, in essence, a profoundly human enterprise. It is not confined to the sterile confines of textbooks or laboratories; rather, it lives and breathes in the interaction between doctor and patient. A physician must learn to listen, to communicate, to empathise, to stand beside the patient not merely as a clinician, but as a fellow human being. Professionalism, though indispensable, must never eclipse compassion. The socio-economic realities of patients often exert a decisive

influence on clinical decisions. At times, treatment strategies may be judiciously modified in accordance with the patient's financial capacity.

Fifthly, the medical profession admits of no indolence. It demands tireless industry, sustained alertness, and an almost ascetic dedication to duty.

Sixthly, a doctor's education does not conclude with the acquisition of degrees; rather, it continues unabated throughout life. Medicine is a dynamic and ever-evolving science. New discoveries, technologies, and treatment modalities continually reshape its landscape. To remain relevant and effective, a physician must commit to lifelong learning.

Seventhly, if one is drawn to medicine solely by the prospect of financial gain, it is, in all likelihood, a misplaced aspiration.

Eighthly, integrity constitutes the moral bedrock of medical practice. In this field, even the slightest error may have irrevocable consequences. Thus, beyond technical competence, honesty, ethical conduct, and a deep sense of responsibility are indispensable. One cannot hope to be a good doctor without first being a good human being.

The journey to becoming a doctor is long, arduous, and often unforgiving. The attain-

ment of an MBBS degree alone requires approximately four and a half to five years, followed by a year of compulsory internship. Only thereafter does one formally earn the designation of a doctor, though practical competence at this stage remains limited. True proficiency demands further immersion in clinical practice. Medicine, in its truest sense, is both a science and an art, transmitted through mentorship, observation, and hands-on experience.

Those who aspire to specialise must confront the formidable challenge of postgraduate entrance examinations – tests of considerable rigour and competition. Success opens the door to MD or MS programmes, entailing three additional years of intensive study and clinical responsibility. Even then, the journey is far from complete. Super-specialisation through DM or MCh requires yet further examinations, followed by three more years of exacting training.

This prolonged journey is marked by profound sacrifice. It entails countless sleepless nights, relentless work, and the gradual erosion of personal and familial comforts. The concept of fixed working hours is virtually alien to this profession. One may be required to work

continuously for 12, 24, or even 48 hours.

The relationship between doctor and patient, once regarded with near-reverential sanctity, is now often perceived as strained. However, this deterioration cannot be attributed solely to one party. Patients and their families must recognise that doctors, too, are human beings, susceptible to fatigue, hunger, and emotional strain. Conversely, doctors must remain sensitive to the immense anxiety and vulnerability experienced by patients and their loved ones.

Misconceptions regarding medical expenses further complicate matters. A prevalent belief persists that the bulk of hospital bills accrues to the doctor. In reality, only a small fraction reaches the physician; the majority is consumed by the costs of medicines, equipment, infrastructure, and institutional maintenance.

It is also frequently alleged that doctors are reluctant to serve in rural settings. While it is undeniable that rural populations are fully entitled to quality healthcare, the ground realities present formidable challenges. Rural hospitals often lack the necessary infrastructure to manage complex medical conditions. Doctors, being the most immediate and visible representatives of the healthcare system, inevitably become the recipients of such dissatisfaction.

And yet, despite the innumerable hardships, sacrifices, and challenges that define this profession, it offers a reward that is beyond all material measure – the sight of a patient restored to health, the quiet smile of relief, the gratitude reflected in the eyes of those who have suffered. In that singular moment, all fatigue, all deprivation, all struggle recedes into insignificance. There is, perhaps, no greater fulfilment than alleviating human suffering. That profound sense of purpose and accomplishment is, in every sense, priceless.

Views expressed are personal

Engineered Chaos?

What appears as isolated mob violence in Malda may, in fact, reflect deeper undercurrents of organised influence, misinformation campaigns, and cross-border strategic interests

Advocate Mofakerul Islam, a native of village Porsa, Etahar, district North Dinajpur, West Bengal, who practices law in Kolkata HC, and his YouTuber friend Ekramul Bagani, also from the same native place, were nabbed by the West Bengal CID from Bagdogra airport in North Bengal while trying to escape to Bangalore after creating havoc in Malda district on April 1. In a sensational and sensitive incident, seven judicial officials, three women among them, who were deputed for the speedy disposal of SIR cases, were held hostage by an unruly mob led by Mofakerul. Advocate Mofakerul was the mastermind, the main culprit behind the incident. He provoked the mob for widespread violence, terrorising the judicial officials for hours without food and water, through hate speech, undermining his legal profession by taking the law into his own hands. The judicial officials were rescued in the early hours of April 2 by the police led by a senior IPS officer, Mr Jayaraman. 35 people were also arrested by the police, besides Mofakerul and Ekramul Bagani, who were nabbed by the West Bengal CID team. Malda district of West Bengal borders Bangladesh. Radical Jamaat-e-Islami has won some parliamentary seats, and that is disturbing for the security of India.

Cutting across political party lines, the ruling TMC, BJP, and Congress have all condemned the incident and demanded strict action against elements responsible for disturbing the peace and law and order in the area. Local TMC leader Hasim Uddin Ahmed from Malda expressed his concern about a conspiracy by outside elements such as the jihadi lobby of Pakistan or Bangladesh. It takes an interesting turn from this point. The majority of political leaders are not well informed about the intricate spy web spun geopolitically and its resultant implications. This is a subject which a limited number of people know and follow, only those who have an interest or in-depth knowledge in the subject. Hence, at times, when Kaliachak-type incidents take place, or for that matter, Pulwama or even Op-Indoor, social media and the mainstream media report allegations and counter-allegations of various political parties, which actually do not focus on the complex nature of the



A local flashpoint in Malda may conceal deeper networks of influence, coordination and calculated unrest

factual issues that remain buried deep down beneath layers of propaganda and misinformation.

Informed people with geopolitical know-how are aware of the dangerous game Turkey is involved in in the region, including in India, mainly in J&K, Kerala, West Bengal, and, of late, in the North Eastern region of the country, besides the adjacent Bangladesh, for quite some time now. In fact, IHH, a Turkish organisation with similar activities like Al-Qaeda, and that is why it is often referred to as the Turkish Al-Qaeda, along with the Turkish publicity wing TRT (Turkish Radio and Television), which serves as the mouthpiece of the majority of the Islamist lobby, has been engaged in building a fake narrative through a massive misinformation war in India. It started with J&K, where Recep Tayyip Erdogan tried playing the role of the 'Masha' for the family members of terrorists who lost their lives during various operations with the security forces. Especially during Eid, he would send messages to all such families, invoking cheap sentiment and trying to gain popularity with the sole intention of Islamisation. Besides J&K, Ankara has been on overdrive in building fake narratives for Islamisation in Kerala, West Bengal, and in the recent past in Mizoram, Manipur, and other parts of North East India. Turkish involvement was also evident in Bangladesh at the time of unrest and the ultimate resultant dethron-

ing of the Sheikh Hasina regime.

Erdogan has been active in re-establishing the Caliphate and Islamic hegemony since the time he acquired power. Initially, as the Prime Minister of Turkey, he assumed power on March 14, 2003, and later became the President in 2014 and ultimately changed to the Presidential form of government, acquiring maximum political power in 2018. Turkey under Erdogan has been funding organisations, groups, and individuals through various Turkish apparatus. He has kept on increasing the budget with heavy investment in the media to tap various think tanks and such organisations which help his cause. Additionally, he has been helping the Pakistan ISI and other jihadi radical groups in Pakistan, Bangladesh, and Myanmar, training different anti-Indian splinter groups through mercenaries to destabilise India, which is a dangerous national security threat to Indian sovereignty. In Bangladesh, he has activated the Lashkar-e-Taiba; in Pakistan, he works closely with several terror organisations and the ISI in order to spread his tentacles in the North Eastern part of India. It is believed that the recent arrest of the American mercenary Matthew Van Dyke by the NIA from Dum Dum airport in Kolkata, along with six Ukrainians and many other operatives arrested from Lucknow and Delhi, are linked with Turkey's larger game plan to destabilise and spread unrest in India with a clear intention of Islamisa-

tion. To propagate the false narrative, he has several activists and journalists, both from the mainstream and social media, on his regular payroll. The modus operandi is to build sympathy towards Islamic causes in order to achieve the larger goal of Islamism. He has the ambition to spread the Neo-Ottoman Empire, for which arms and ammunition are supplied, besides money distributed randomly to target individuals, organisations, and countries, be it for generating sympathy towards Hamas, Iran, or any such causes. Propaganda or the information war also includes tarnishing the image of Indian nationalist leaders against payment, which is normally made through Bitcoin and cryptocurrency. The travel itinerary of such persons engaged in building and spreading fake narratives, if monitored, will reveal and confirm that it is not always Dubai, but more popular destinations now are Thailand, Nepal, the UK, etc., where such dubious acts and exchanges are conducted.

There are two misinformation warfare hubs in this region: while Pakistan is a non-NATO terror-building factory, Turkey is a NATO nation involved in such nefarious activities. Both Pakistan and Turkey are partners in spreading jihadi terror with a common goal to target India and other non-Muslim countries. That is why they have more than a thousand terror sleeper cells in Europe, which are currently operating.

Precisely in this context, the role of Mofakerul and Ekramul is significant. The plot is thick, complex, and multi-layered. The security agencies would be trying to extract specific inputs to unearth the larger game plan, to take steps to keep the nation free from such unholy activities, and it becomes the moral responsibility of the citizens to apprise the agencies in order to keep our nation safe.

Even in the past, irrespective of political differences, all opposition political parties have always joined hands with the government to strengthen the resolve to act and punish the culprits, whether individuals, organisations, or any rogue country. The challenges and threats are serious and, under all circumstances, should be tackled effectively with awareness building and cohesive actions by all citizens.

Views expressed are personal

RBI MPC begins policy meet, decision on April 8

RBI has cut rates by a total of 125 bps since Feb 2025, marking its most aggressive easing cycle since 2019

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI: The Reserve Bank's rate-setting panel on Monday started its three-day brainstorming session on the first bi-monthly monetary policy of the fiscal amid expectations of a status quo on the benchmark lending rate in view of apprehensions of a spike in inflation due to ongoing West Asia crisis.

The decision of the six-member Monetary Policy Committee (MPC), headed by Reserve Bank Governor Sanjay Malhotra, will be announced on April 8 (Wednesday).

The RBI has cut rates by a total of 125 basis points (bps) since February 2025, marking its most aggressive easing cycle since 2019.

It last reduced the rate by 25 basis points in December and maintained status in its last meeting in February.

According to experts, the MPC members will take into account the continuing geopolitical tensions in West Asia, volatility in commodity prices and sharp currency movement hitting the value of the domestic currency.

They noted that while retail inflation has moved closer to



It last reduced the rate by 25 basis points in December and maintained status in its last meeting in February

the RBI's medium-term target of 4 per cent, the recent surge in global crude oil prices has raised concerns about potential second-round effects on domestic prices, particularly fuel, transportation, and core inflation components.

As per estimates, every \$10 increase in crude prices per barrel stokes inflation by up to 0.60 per cent.

Crude prices, which were in the \$60 per barrel vicinity for a long time, have hardened to over \$100 since the start of the

Highlights

- » MPC will take into account the continuing geopolitical tensions in West Asia, volatility in commodity prices, sharp currency movement
- » As per estimates, every \$10 increase in crude prices per barrel stokes inflation by up to 0.60 per cent
- » Rupee has declined over 4 per cent since war, which has consequences for pushing up import inflation

conflict in late February.

Additionally, the rupee has depreciated by over 4 per cent since the war, which has consequences for pushing up import inflation.

Experts are also of the view that the central bank will retain its current policy neutral stance in the upcoming review, reflecting a preference to maintain flexibility amid evolving inflation dynamics and global uncertainties.

The tone of the policy is expected to remain cautious

and watchful, with policymakers likely to highlight upside risks to inflation from volatile crude oil prices and geopolitical tensions.

Economists further said liquidity conditions, transmission of past rate changes, and financial market stability will remain key considerations for policymakers.

The RBI is also expected to closely monitor currency movements, capital flows, and bond market dynamics while calibrating its policy stance.

The government has asked the Reserve Bank to maintain retail inflation at 4 per cent with a margin of 2 per cent on either side for another five years ending March 2031.

India, it may be recalled, adopted the inflation-targeting framework in 2016 and the six-member MPC was given the mandate to maintain annual inflation at 4 per cent until March 31, 2021, with an upper tolerance of 6 per cent and a lower threshold of 2 per cent.

The framework has been retained since then.

According to the latest data, retail inflation in the country rose to 3.21 per cent in February from 2.74 per cent in the preceding month.

India's service sector growth rises at softest pace in 14 mnths in March

'As such, service providers' expectations for future activity remained positive,' said Pranjul Bhandari, Chief India Economist at HSBC

OUR CORRESPONDENT

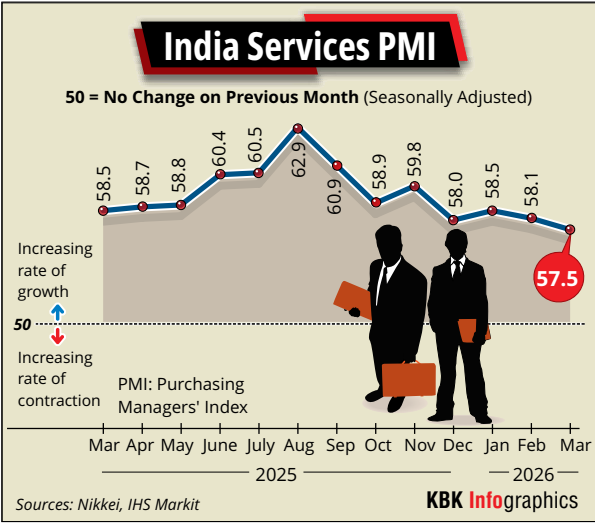
NEW DELHI: India's services sector growth momentum rose at the softest pace in 14 months in March, mirroring the slowdown in new business intakes, a monthly survey said on Monday. The seasonally adjusted HSBC India Services PMI Business Activity Index fell from 58.1 in February to 57.5 in March, amid the weakest rises in new business and activity since January 2025.

In the PMI parlance, a print above 50 means expansion, while a score below 50 denotes contraction.

"India's services sector stayed in expansion in March, but growth momentum eased for a second consecutive month. Demand remained resilient, led by new export orders, which rose to the greatest extent since mid-2024. As such, service providers' expectations for future activity remained positive," said Pranjul Bhandari, Chief India Economist at HSBC.

However, the services sector recorded quicker expansions in new export orders. Panellists noted gains from Africa, Asia, Australia, Europe, the Americas and the Middle East.

On the price front, selling charge inflation quickened to a seven-month high amid the steepest increase in input costs since June 2022. According



However, the services sector recorded quicker expansions in new export orders. Panellists noted gains from Africa, Asia, Australia, Europe, the Americas and the Middle East

to panel members, outlays on chicken, cooking oil, eggs, electricity, fish, fruits, fuel, labour, meat and vegetables all rose since February. "... Input cost inflation accelerated to its fastest pace since 2022, indicating that higher fuel, transport and logistics costs are feeding into services," Bhandari said.

Out of the four broad areas of the service economy moni-

tored by the survey, the quickest increases in input costs and output charges were seen in Consumer Services and Finance & Insurance, respectively, the survey noted. Regarding employment, the latest results showed a third consecutive monthly increase. Moreover, the pace of job creation was solid and the strongest since mid-2025 amid a pick-up in business confidence.

Rupee rises 28 paise to 92.90 against dollar



MUMBAI: The rupee gained 28 paise to close at 92.90 against the US dollar on Monday, following the Reserve Bank's measures to curb speculative fervour and dampen volatility in the Indian currency.

Forex traders said that though the RBI measures are rupee-positive, unabated withdrawal of foreign capital, a strengthening dollar, and rising crude oil prices amid a volatile geopolitical situation continue to put pressure on the rupee.

The RBI tightened its rules to curb speculative positions and capped banks' net open positions at \$100 million.

At the interbank foreign exchange, the rupee opened at 93.13 against the US dollar and in intraday trade gained momentum to touch a high of 92.79 against the greenback.

At the end of Monday's trading session, the rupee was quoted at 92.90 against the dollar, up 28 paise from its previous closing level.

Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback's strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading 0.15 per cent lower at 99.87.

Markets stage sharp rebound on softening crude oil prices, Sensex jumps 787 points

MUMBAI: Benchmark indices Sensex and Nifty staged a sharp rebound on Monday after falling in early trade following a correction in crude oil prices amid reports of ceasefire efforts in the ongoing West Asia war.

Intense buying in banking and IT stocks, and a strengthening rupee, supported investor sentiment, traders said.

In a volatile session, the 30-share BSE Sensex jumped 787.30 points, or 1.07 per cent, to settle at 74,106.85. During the day, it surged 887.91 points, or 1.21 per cent, to 74,207.46.

A total of 3,207 stocks advanced, while 1,147 declined and 190 remained unchanged on the BSE.

The 50-share NSE Nifty edged higher by 255.15 points, or 1.12 per cent, to end at 22,968.25.



From the 30-Sensex firms, Trent jumped the most by 7.89 per cent. Axis Bank, Titan, Larsen & Toubro, UltraTech Cement and Bajaj Finance were also among the major gainers.

On the other hand, Reliance Industries and Sun Pharma

were the laggards.

Sectorally, BSE PSU Bank surged 2.37 per cent, Consumer Durables (2.30 per cent), Private Banks index (2.15 per cent), Financial Services (2.12 per cent), BSE Top 10 Banks (2.07 per cent), Bankex (2.03

per cent) and utilities (1.94 per cent). In contrast, energy and oil & gas were the laggards.

Consumer durables emerged as the top performer, supported by a strong demand outlook and interest in consumption-led themes. IT stocks also outperformed, with the Nifty IT index gaining on the back of rupee movements and defensive buying amid geopolitical uncertainty, as currency weakness supports export-oriented earnings.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, dropped 0.71 per cent to \$108.3 per barrel.

FII offloaded equities worth Rs 9,931.13 crore on Thursday, according to exchange data. Domestic Institutional Investors (DIIs), however, bought stocks worth Rs 7,208.41 crore.

NSO launches first-ever Annual Survey of incorporated services sector enterprises with reference period of 2024-25

The NSO will use GSTN database as a sampling frame & survey over 1.21 lakh enterprises

NEW DELHI: The National Statistics Office (NSO) on Monday announced the launch of the first-ever Annual Survey of Incorporated Services Sector Enterprises, with its first reference period of 2024-25.

According to an official statement, the NSO will use the GSTN database as a sampling frame and survey more than 1.21 lakh enterprises in the survey. Annual Survey of Incorporated Services Sector Enterprises (ASISSE) will begin from April 2026, covering all states and Union Territories; accompanied by an explainer document titled Know Your Survey:

A User Guide to the Annual Survey of Incorporated Services Sector Enterprises (ASISSE), designed specifically for communicating the study processes in a user-friendly manner.

In terms of economic significance, the services sector contributes more than half of India's GDP, generates millions of jobs and has been a major catalyst for the country's economic transformation in the last few decades. ASISSE is envisaged to be a key source of official data on the incorporated services sector of the economy, comprising services like trade, transport, hospitality, information tech-

Unincorporated non-agri sector excluding construction is covered by Survey of Unincorporated Sector Enterprises

nology, education, health, etc., and thereby, representing one of the most dynamic components of India's economy.

It is a significant initiative aimed at developing a comprehensive database of the incor-

porated services sector in India.

A comparable database for the registered manufacturing sector already exists through the Annual Survey of Industries (ASI), conducted by the NSO.

The unincorporated non-agricultural sector (excluding construction) is covered by the Annual Survey of Unincorporated Sector Enterprises (ASUSE).

Together, these three surveys provide a holistic view of the non-agricultural economy, capturing key indicators at state and industry levels. The survey covers corporate entities in the services sector – companies

registered under the Companies Act, 1956/2013 or Limited Liability Partnership Act, 2008.

With a sample size of approximately 1.21 lakh enterprises, the survey is expected to generate key operational and economic indicators, which are crucial for evidence-based policymaking and economic analysis.

It will be conducted under the provisions of the Collection of Statistics Act, 2008, as amended in 2017 and through the Jan Vishwas (Amendment of Provisions) Act, 2023, and data will be collected through a secure web-based portal.

CLOSER LOOK

- » 'A total of 747 investment proposals worth Rs 17,217 crore were received by the department in FY26'
- » And 317 investors allotted 404 acres land through the Bihar Industrial Development Authority, Bihar Industries Minister Dilip Jaiswal said
- » According to a statement issued by the department, 109 startups registered themselves in 2025-26

trial Development Authority," Jaiswal told reporters here.

The Integrated Manufacturing City (IMC) in Gaya Ji, textile and bag manufacturing cluster in Muzaffarpur, mega food park at Damodarpar,

multi-modal logistics park and proposed Fintech City in Patna's Fatuha locality were among the major industrial projects initiated by the department in the last one year, he said.

The minister said 13,343

CORPORATE KALEIDOSCOPE



An Official Language Implementation Committee meeting was organised on Monday at Rail Coach Factory, Kapurthala for effective implementation of Official Language (Raj Bhasha) policy. The meeting was chaired by the GM, RCF Kapurthala, Ajay Nandan. Senior Rajbhasha Officer Vinod Katoch presented a comprehensive report highlighting usage of Hindi in official work during the previous quarter. On this occasion, prizes were distributed to the winners of various competitions organised during Hindi Pakhwada. The annual publication of Rajbhasha Department, 'Arunodaya,' was also released during the meeting.

PhonePe SBI Card launches first year fee waiver to widen access

NEW DELHI: PhonePe has introduced a limited-time offer on its newly launched PhonePe SBI Card, waiving the joining fee and making it free for the first year to widen access to premium rewards.

Issued in partnership with SBI, the card is available on both RuPay and Visa networks and is tailored for digital-first users.

The card offers a flat 5 per cent reward on all online purchases across brands, along with 10 per cent rewards on key PhonePe categories such as recharges, utility payments, bill payments and LPG bookings.



Users can also save 10 per cent on insurance premium payments made via the platform, while everyday UPI transactions through RuPay Scan n Pay earn 1 per cent rewards, extending benefits to routine spends.

Travel benefits include complimentary access to domestic

airport lounges up to four times a year with-out any spending threshold, along with a two-year Priority Pass membership for international lounge access, enhancing the overall travel experience.

Reward points earned can be directly redeemed against the credit card bill, with each point valued at Rs 1, enabling users to reduce their monthly outstanding amount. The rewards are subject to applicable limits and terms.

The card can be applied for seamlessly through the PhonePe app, offering a fully digital onboarding process.

PATNA: Bihar Industries Minister Dilip Jaiswal on Monday said the state government aims to attract investments to the tune of Rs 50 lakh crore and generate one crore employment over the next five years.

He asserted that industrial development has been accorded top priority under the government's 'Saat Nischay' programme.

"A total of 747 investment proposals worth Rs 17,217 crore were received by the department in the 2025-26 financial year, and 317 investors were allotted 404 acres of land through the Bihar Indus-

'Bihar govt aims to attract ₹50L cr investments in 5 years'

'Development has been accorded top priority under the government's 'Saat Nischay' programme'

acres of land across 24 districts were approved for industrial projects during the last fiscal year, while 1,670 acres have been acquired for the IMC in Gaya Ji, which is part of the Amritsar-Kolkata Industrial Corridor (AKIC) project.

According to a statement issued by the department, 109 startups registered themselves in 2025-26, and the government supported 1,652 ventures, including 242 women-led startups, by disbursing Rs 92.2 crore.

During 2025-26, loans exceeding Rs 468 crore

were disbursed under the Pradhan Mantri Formalisation of Micro Food Processing Enterprises (PMFME) scheme, with cumulative figure surpassing Rs 1,345 crore, it said.

Jaiswal said that under Mukhyamantri Udyami Yojana, Rs 3,242 crore assistance was provided to 44,179 beneficiaries during 2025-26, and over 6.5 lakh applications have been received so far in the current fiscal.

He also said that the banking sector has been urged to lend more to the entrepreneurs of Bihar.

Automobile retail sales up 13.30% at 2,96,71,064 units in FY26: FADA

PV retail sales rose to 47.05,056 units in FY26, up 13% from 41,63,927 units in FY25, Federation of Automobile Dealers Associations said

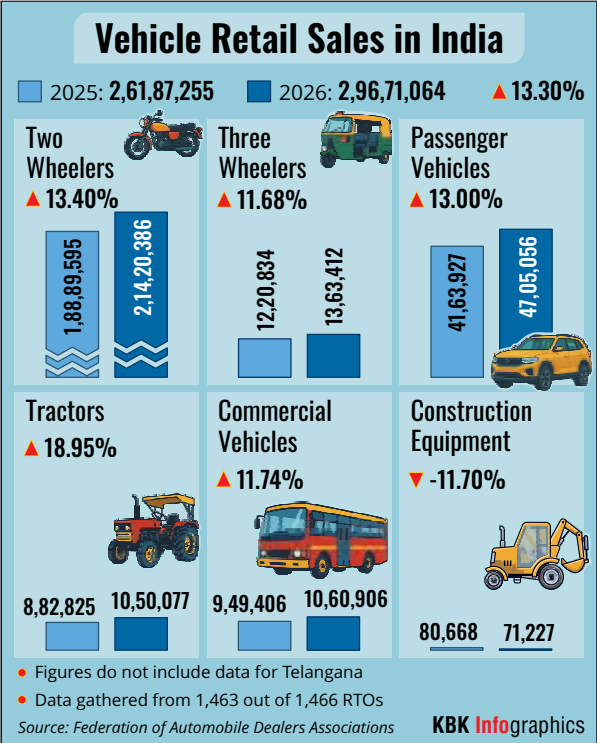
OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Retail sales of vehicles across categories in India in FY26 grew by 13.30 per cent at a record 2,96,71,064 units as compared to 2,61,87,255 units in the previous fiscal, with GST 2.0 helping overcome a subdued start to the year, Federation of Automobile Dealers Associations said on Monday.

Passenger vehicle (PV) retail sales rose to 47,05,056 units in FY26, up 13 per cent from 41,63,927 units in FY25, the Federation of Automobile Dealers Associations (FADA) said in a statement, adding that it is cautiously optimistic but watchful of the possible impact of West Asia war on vehicles demand in India going forward.

Similarly, two-wheeler sales also grew by 13.40 per cent at 2,14,20,386 in FY26 as compared to 1,88,89,595 units in FY25. In FY26, three-wheeler retail sales stood at 13,63,412 units, up 11.68 per cent from 12,20,834 units in FY25, FADA said.

Commercial vehicles retail also witnessed a growth of 11.74 per cent at 10,60,906 units in FY26 as against 9,49,406 units in FY25, it added. Commenting on the industry performance, FADA President C S Vignesh-



Highlights

- » 'The turning point arrived in Sept with the GST 2.0 implementation'
- » The rate rationalisation, reduced the effective tax burden on mass-segment two-wheelers, small cars, three-wheelers, and select commercial categories
- » From September onwards, the festive convergence of Navratri and Diwali in October delivered an all-time record monthly retail of over 40 lakh units
- » On the outlook, FADA said, 'Key variable will be trajectory of West Asia situation & its pass-through to fuel prices'

with monthly growth ranging between 2-5 per cent as the market navigated residual caution from the previous year's sluggish inventory cycle, selective financing constraints, and consumer wait-and-watch behaviour in anticipation of policy clarity. "The turning point arrived in September with the implementation of GST 2.0. The rate rationalisation, which meaningfully reduced the effective tax burden on mass-segment two-wheelers, small cars, three-wheelers, and select commercial categories, improved real affordability at a time when the consumer was already positioned to respond," Vigneshwar said.

From September onwards, the festive convergence of Navratri and Diwali in October delivered an all-time record monthly retail of over 40 lakh units, and the momentum carried through the remainder of the year. January, February, and March 2026 each registered strong double-digit YoY growth, validating that the upshift was not merely festive but structural, he said.

On the outlook, FADA said, "The key variable will be the trajectory of the West Asia situation and its pass-through to fuel prices, supply availability, and overall consumer confidence."

Two LPG tankers sail through Strait of Hormuz

NEW DELHI: Two more Indian-flagged LPG tankers have safely crossed the war-hit Strait of Hormuz and are headed for Indian ports even as 16 other vessels remain stranded in the Persian Gulf, officials said Monday.

LPG vessel Green Sanvi carrying 46,650 tonnes of LPG is scheduled to reach Indian port on April 7 while Green Asha with 15,500 tonnes of cargo is scheduled to touch Indian coast on April 9, said Mukesh Mangal, Additional Secretary in Ministry of Ports, Shipping & Waterways at a news briefing.

"Indian maritime operations remain safe and uninterrupted amid West Asia crisis. 16 Indian-flagged vessels with 433 seafarers are in the region; two LPG carriers, Green Sanvi and Green Asha, safely crossed Strait of Hormuz," he said.

With this, eight Indian-flagged LPG tankers have safely



transited through the strategic waterway, which has remained effectively shut since the US and Israel launched attacks on Iran on February 28 and Tehran's sweeping retaliation.

Of the vessels still stuck in the Persian Gulf, one is of a loaded liquefied natural gas (LNG), two are LPG tankers (one loaded and one empty), six are crude carriers (five loaded, one empty), three are container ships, one is a dredger, one is

carrying chemical cargo and two are bulk carriers, he said.

Asked about reports of Iran charging a fee for letting ships cross the strait, Mangal said, "we have no information of such payments."

For a country that relies on imports from Gulf nations to meet as much as 60 per cent of its cooking gas needs, the arrivals will help ease the worst LPG shortage it is battling in decades. India consumed 33.15 million

BCAS, Rashtriya Raksha University partner for local aviation security testing facility

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Bureau of Civil Aviation Security (BCAS) and Rashtriya Raksha University (RRU) have signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) to establish a dedicated indigenous testing centre for aviation security equipment, including Full Body Scanners (FBS), used at airports across India.

Equipment tested there helps secure Indian airport checkpoints. Instead of relying on foreign facilities, assessments will now happen locally. Work under this MoU strengthens national capability in aviation safety tech. Testing standards will align with operational needs at terminals nationwide.

The agreement was signed in the presence of Civil Aviation



Minister Ram Mohan Naidu Kinjarapu, Civil Aviation Secretary Samir Kumar Sinha, BCAS Director General Rajesh Nirwan and RRU Vice Chancellor Bimal Patel.

A new facility is set to test how well security gear works at airports, checking devices through structured trials before giving official approval. By building its own system based on measurable results, the country moves toward self-reliance in verifying tech used nationwide. Government representatives noted this shift supports stronger air travel safeguards without depending heavily on outside validation methods.

Around this agreement, RRU takes charge of launch-

ing and running the lab alongside BCAS. Equipment from makers lands here first, facing real scrutiny before any paperwork moves forward. Specs get checked thoroughly - nothing slips through unchecked. Reports come out clear, built only on what was tested, meant for official review down the line.

Now comes a plan for high-level test labs built to match worldwide norms, keeping tight control over how safe things are, whether gear works together, and if it performs right. These steps go hand in hand with setting up a stamp of approval process so only trusted devices make it into critical flight zones.

Together, they'll work on shared studies, learning sessions, hands-on events, while exchanging insights to grow skills in aviation safety tech.

Vedanta, HZL eye rare earth magnet scheme pre-bid meet



NEW DELHI: Several companies, including Vedanta and Hindustan Zinc Limited, are likely to participate in a pre-bid conference for the Rs 7,280-crore scheme to promote the manufacturing of sintered rare earth permanent magnet called by the Heavy Industries Ministry on Tuesday, sources said.

The government, on March 20, invited bids for setting up manufacturing facilities for 6,000 metric tonnes per annum (MTPA) of magnets under the scheme.

The heavy industries ministry came out with a request for proposal (RFP) for the selection of beneficiaries to establish integrated sintered NdFeB rare earth permanent magnet manufacturing units.

The pre-bid conference will be held on April 7, while the bidding date is May 28.

Technical bids will be opened on May 29, 2026. PTI

Govt eases norms for mining of deep-seated critical minerals

NEW DELHI: The government on Monday notified amendments to the mining concession rules, allowing licensed operators to expand exploration, a move which is likely to unlock deep-seated critical minerals and help in efforts towards self-reliance in the sector. The amendments will enable the inclusion of contiguous areas in mining leases and composite licences, as well as the addition of associated minerals to leases of major and minor minerals.

Allowing inclusion of contiguous area will promote optimal mining of deep-seated minerals, which are locked up in contiguous areas and may not be economically viable to

be extracted under a separate lease or licence, the mines ministry said in a statement. The amended rules lay down a simple and time-bound process for holders of mining leases or composite licences for deep-seated minerals to apply for a one-time addition of nearby land, it said.

The added area cannot exceed 10 per cent of the existing lease area or 30 per cent of the licence area. For auctioned leases, the holder must pay 10 per cent of the auction premium on minerals from the added land, while non-auctioned lease holders need to pay an amount equal to the royalty on such output, it said. The reforms ush-

ered in by the amendment give impetus to the mining sector to increase the supply of minerals for industries, leading to strengthening Atmanirbhar Bharat, the statement said.

The amendments provide the inclusion of any other mineral, including a minor mineral, in a mining lease and mandate states to permit such inclusion within 30 days of the application. No additional amount is applicable on inclusion of critical and strategic mineral or deep-seated minerals specified in 7th Schedule to the MMDR Act to incentivise production of these minerals, which are found in small quantity & are difficult to mine & process, it said. PTI

Silver jumps ₹5K, gold up by ₹2,300

NEW DELHI: Silver prices jumped Rs 5,000 to Rs 2.42 lakh per kg in the national capital on Monday, while gold advanced to Rs 1.53 lakh per 10 grams due to easing crude oil rates and a weak US dollar.

The white metal appreciated by Rs 5,000, or 2.11 per cent, to Rs 2,42,000 per kg from Friday's closing level of Rs 2,37,000 per kg.

Gold of 99.9 per cent purity also advanced by Rs 2,300, or 1.52 per cent, to Rs 1,53,800 per 10 grams. In the international market, spot silver rose 0.5 per cent to \$73.37 per ounce and gold gained 0.14 per cent to \$4,682.80 per ounce. PTI

NSE and S&P Global Energy tie-up for derivatives launch

MUMBAI: The National Stock Exchange (NSE) on Monday announced a strategic collaboration with S&P Global Energy to introduce exchange-traded derivatives based on its Platts physical spot market benchmarks. This marks a significant step in deepening India's energy derivatives ecosystem and aligning it with globally recognized pricing standards.

As part of this collaboration, NSE will initially launch Dated Brent Crude Oil (Platts) futures contracts based on the Platts Dated Brent benchmark. The exchange aims to provide market participants with a robust, transparent, and globally relevant risk management tool linked to internationally trusted energy reference prices.



The proposed contracts are designed to aid a wide spectrum of market participants, including refiners, importers, traders, financial institutions, and investors seeking exposure to global Brent crude oil markets through a regulated domestic platform.

NSE has received approval from the Regulator to launch the Dated Brent Crude Oil (Platts) Futures. The Exchange has announced that they will be launching the contracts on April 13, 2026. MPOST

IRFC sanctions ₹1K crore to Maha state power generation co

NEW DELHI: Indian Railway Finance Corporation (IRFC) on Monday said it has sanctioned and fully disbursed a Rs 1,000 crore term loan to Maharashtra State Power Generation Company Ltd, reinforcing its role in funding core infrastructure.

The move follows its recent Rs 12,842 crore loan agreement with Hindustan Urvarak & Rasayan Ltd. Calling it a strong start to the financial year, IRFC Chairman and Managing Director Manoj Kumar Dubey said the first disbursement reflects confidence, continuity and commitment, and urged the team to sustain the momentum.

Established in 1986 as the financing arm of the Ministry of Railways, IRFC has been instrumental in mo-bilising long-term funds for rail infrastructure at competitive rates.

It has since diversified into financing sectors linked to the railway ecosystem, including power, transmission, mining, coal, logistics and urban transport. Dubey said IRFC will continue expanding across infrastructure segments while maintaining financial discipline and strong partnerships. MPOST

Textiles market size grows by 8.3% CAGR to ₹14.95 lakh crore in 2024

Man-made fibre, blended fibre-based products are contributing 52.2%, followed by 41.2% by cotton-based products

NEW DELHI: India's textiles market has expanded more than threefold to Rs 14.95 lakh crore in 2024 from Rs 4.89 lakh crore in 2010, clocking a CAGR of 8.3 per cent, according to a Textile Ministry survey released by Giriraj Singh.

The report, "Market for Textiles and Clothing: National House-hold Survey 2024," assesses domestic demand in the household segment.

Man-made fibre (MMF) and blended products now dominate with a 52.2 per cent share, followed by cotton at 41.2 per cent, while silk and wool account for 5.2 per cent and 1.3



per cent, respectively.

In value terms, MMF and blended textiles saw demand rise from Rs 1.47 lakh crore to Rs 4.47 lakh crore (8.28 per cent CAGR), while cotton demand grew from Rs 0.87 lakh crore to Rs 3.53 lakh crore, posting a

CLOSER LOOK

- » Silk and woollen fibre-based products are contributing 5.2% & 1.3%, respectively, to product basket
- » In value terms, MMF & blended textiles saw demand rise from Rs 1.47 lakh cr to Rs 4.47 lakh cr, 8.28% CAGR
- » While cotton demand grew from Rs 0.87 lakh crore to Rs 3.53 lakh crore, posting a faster 10.53 per cent CAGR

faster 10.53 per cent CAGR. Silk and wool segments recorded growth of 8.93 per cent and 7.02 per cent, respectively.

The ministry noted a clear shift in consumer preference toward MMF-based products, even as cotton remains a key sta-

ple. Overall domestic demand has shown robust expansion over the past 15 years, driven largely by households, whose contribution rose from Rs 4.18 lakh crore to Rs 8.77 lakh crore.

Per capita textile demand nearly tripled to Rs 6,066 in

2024 from Rs 2,119 in 2010, growing at a CAGR of 7.8 per cent, reflecting rising consumption.

Women accounted for 55.5 per cent of purchases, compared with 44.5 per cent by men. Commonly demanded products include shirts, sarees, trousers, salwar kameez, jeans, T-shirts and innerwear, with men's jeans emerging as the fastest-growing category, while leggings gained traction among women.

The study also highlights increasing adoption of sustainable textiles, including reused and recycled garments. Demand for such products is

estimated at Rs 37,000 crore in 2024, with reused and retailored items forming about 58 per cent of this segment.

Technical textiles are also gaining ground, with rising demand for items such as masks, sanitary products, wipes, diapers and car seat covers across both rural and urban markets. Rural households account for 58 per cent of technical textile consumption, compared with 42 per cent in urban areas.

The report is expected to guide policymakers and industry stakeholders in shaping future strategies for the sector. AGENCIES

Mumbai seek reset against rampaging RR, Pandya fitness in focus

Meanwhile, Vinicius Jr reiterated his desire to remain at the club as the Brazilian winger nears the final year of his contract. The 25-year-old has endured a mixed campaign, going 16 matches without a goal early in the season and hearing boos from sections of the Bernabeu crowd. AGENCIES

SAQIB SALEEM EYES BIG-SCREEN COMEBACK

The actor is hungry for lead parts after appearing in ‘Kaptaan’

Saqib Saleem is currently appearing in the series ‘Kaptaan’, where he plays SSP Samardeep, a decorated encounter specialist. Samardeep operates in a grey zone where justice often takes priority over procedure. The role has allowed Saqib to explore complex shades in a lead role. Now, the actor is ready for a strong return to the big screen.

In a recent interview, the actor expressed his desire for substantial lead roles that are crafted specifically for him. He discussed his career stage and the type of work he is currently seeking. Saqib also shared his desire to prove himself once again on the big screen.

Saqib Saleem shared in an interview with ‘News 18’ that he is at a stage where he is ‘really looking for roles made for me’. He wants ‘meaty roles’ and added, “I want roles at the headlining stage for myself and I am one of those who, if I really want to work with somebody, reach out to them myself.” He feels he now understands cinema better than he did ten years ago. Saqib hopes that after ‘Kaptaan’, better opportunities will come his way.

The actor expressed his strong wish to return to the big screen. He said, “I’d love to do a theatrical film and I have had success in the theatre mar-



ket, so I want a theatrical film.”

Saqib believes the theatre experience holds a special place in his heart and he wants roles that push him as an artist and allow him to showcase his full skill set. He reflected on his early days as an audience member. “The child who saw a film in Delhi theatres didn’t know OTT. I became an actor because I wanted to be seen in a theatre full of people,” he concluded. This personal connection continues to drive him. He wants to recreate that magic for audiences through meaningful theatrical releases.

Saqib Saleem has built a solid body of work across films and streaming shows. After making his mark in ‘83’, he focused more on digital content. Now he feels ready for bigger challenges on the big screen.

AGENCIES



He plays the character of SSP Samardeep, a decorated encounter specialist

Karishma Tanna & Varun Bhangra announce pregnancy

The couple is expecting their child in August

NEW DELHI: Karishma Tanna said she is expecting her first child with husband and businessman Varun Bhangra.

Tanna, known for her roles in ‘Kyunki Saas Bhi Kabhi Bahu Thi’ and ‘Naagin’, shared a series of pictures on her ‘Instagram’ handle as she announced the news.

The ‘Scoop’ actress is known for her roles in ‘Kyunki Saas Bhi Kabhi Bahu Thi’ and ‘Naagin’

The first picture featured her and Bhangra wearing caps with ‘Mom’ and ‘Dad’ written over them. Followed by pictures of the couple holding the infant’s shoes.

They are expecting the child in August. “A little Miracle. Our greatest gift - August 2026,” read the caption.

Tanna and Bhangra started dating in 2021 but kept their relationship private until the engagement in November of the same year. They tied the knot in February 2022 in an intimate wedding ceremony.

PTI



Screenwriters’ union & H’wood studios reach four-year tentative agreement

The screenwriters’ union and Hollywood studios reached a surprise four-year tentative agreement after roughly three weeks of negotiation.

The ‘Writers Guild of America West’ said on ‘X’ that its negotiating committee unanimously approved a tentative agreement with ‘The Alliance of Motion Picture and Television Producers’, which represents studios.

The alliance confirmed the deal in a separate statement on its website on Saturday. “We look forward to building on this progress as we continue working toward agreements that support long-term industry stability,” read the alliance’s statement.

The precise terms of the deals were not immediately announced. It is expected to include several writers’ priorities, such as better health care plans and more protections against artificial intelligence.

The union said on ‘X’ that the deal protects the writers’ health plan, builds on gains from 2023 and ‘helps address free work challenges’.

The contract agreement, a year longer than a typical three-year deal, must be approved by the guild’s board and members before it is ratified. The surprise agreement came within weeks of negotiation, a stark contrast to the contentious contract negotiation three years ago, when



The alliance confirmed the deal in a separate statement on its website

the SAG-AFTRA, said in a February interview with ‘The Associated Press’ that he has seen signs that the studios want ‘to work as partners again’. Hollywood actors also walked out of their jobs for months in 2023, demanding a better contract.

The writers’ tentative deal with studios came as the ‘Writers Guild of America West’ faces an ongoing strike by its own staff union that started in February.

More than 100 people working in legal, events and residuals departments went on strike over allegations of unfair labour practice, according to the ‘Los Angeles Times’. It isn’t clear how, or whether, the weeklong strike would have an impact on the tentative deal with the studios. The union announced last month that it had cancelled its annual award ceremony because of the staff union strike.

AGENCIES



SQUARE YARDS

Shreya buys residential unit in Mumbai for a total of Rs 29.70 cr

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Indian playback singer Shreya Ghoshal, along with her mother Shamishtha Ghoshal and father Biswajit Ghoshal, has purchased an apartment in Worli, Mumbai, for Rs 29.70 crore, according to property registration documents reviewed by ‘Square Yards’ on the website of ‘Inspector General of Registration’ (IGR) <https://igrmaharashtra.gov.in>. The transaction was registered in April 2026.

Worli enjoys exceptional connectivity to Mumbai’s key commercial districts and lifestyle hubs, making it one of the city’s most premium and strategically located localities. The area is well connected via the Bandra-Worli Sea Link, Annie Besant Road and the Western Express Highway, ensuring seamless access to both South Mumbai and the western suburbs. Over the years, Worli has transformed

into a high-end residential and commercial destination, marked by luxury high-rises, premium office spaces and upscale social infrastructure. The locality offers proximity to major business districts such as Bandra Kurla Complex, Lower Parel and Nariman Point, while also being near leading retail centres, fine dining restaurants, reputed schools and top healthcare facilities. Its blend of waterfront views, connectivity and urban sophistication makes Worli a preferred address for professionals, corporates and high-net-worth individuals seeking a premium lifestyle.

According to the IGR property registration documents reviewed by ‘Square Yards’, the property is in Godrej Trilogy, Worli. The purchased apartment features a carpet area of 2,430.06 sq. ft. (225.76 sq. m.) and a total area of 2,750.28 sq. ft. (255.51 sq. m.). It comes with a total of three car parking spaces. The

transaction incurred a stamp duty payment of Rs. 1.78 crore and registration charges of Rs. 30,000.

Shreya Ghoshal is an acclaimed Indian playback singer, widely regarded as one of the finest voices in Indian music. She was born to Bishwajit Ghoshal, an electrical engineer and Sarmistha Ghoshal, a literature post-graduate. She rose to prominence after winning the reality show ‘Sa Re Ga Ma Pa’ and made her Bollywood debut with ‘Devdas’ (2002), gaining recognition for songs like ‘Bairi Piya’. Over the years, she has sung numerous hit songs across multiple languages, including Hindi, Bengali, Tamil, Telugu and Malayalam. Known for her versatility, emotive singing, and strong classical foundation, she has received several prestigious awards, including multiple National Film Awards, while maintaining a graceful and respected public image.

CHETAK SCREEN AWARDS 2026

Aditya Dhar’s directorial ‘DHURANDHAR’ bags 14 awards

In the top categories, ‘Best Director’ was awarded to Aditya Dhar



The Chetak Screen Awards 2026 honoured the finest in Indian cinema, with ‘Dhurandhar’ emerging as the biggest winner of the night with 14 awards.

The coveted ‘Best Film’ award went to ‘Homebound’, which was up against a strong slate of nominees including ‘Dhadak 2’, ‘Dhurandhar’, ‘Haq’, ‘Saiyaara’, ‘Sitaare Zameen Par’, ‘Superboys of Malegaon’ and ‘Chhaava’.

In the top categories, ‘Best Director’ was awarded to Aditya Dhar, from a competitive line-up that also included Laxman Ramchandra Utekar (‘Chhaava’), Suparn S Varma (‘Haq’), Neeraj Ghaywan (‘Homebound’), Raam Reddy (‘Jugnuma: The Fable’), Mohit Suri (‘Saiyaara’) and Reema Kagti (‘Superboys of Malegaon’).

‘Best Actor (Male)’ went to Ranveer Singh, beating nominees Vicky Kaushal (‘Chhaava’), Siddhant Chaturvedi (‘Dhadak 2’), Vishal Jethwa (‘Homebound’), Ishaan Khatter (‘Homebound’), Manoj Bajpayee (‘Jugnuma: The Fable’) and Adarsh Gourav (‘Superboys of Malegaon’).

‘Best Actor (Female)’ was awarded to Yami Gautam, emerging from a strong field of nominees that included Triptii Dimri (‘Dhadak 2’), Sonal Madhusankar (‘Humans in the Loop’), Konkona Sen Sharma (‘Metro... In Dino’), Monika Panwar (‘Nishaanchi’), Radhika Apte (‘Sister Midnight’) and Kriti Sanon (‘Tere Ishk Mein’).

On the OTT front, ‘Best OTT Film’ went to ‘Stolen’, competing against ‘Mrs’, ‘Raat Akeli Hai: The Bansal Murders’, ‘The Great Shamsuddin Family’ and ‘The Mehta Boys’.

The top acting honours in the digital space went to Abhishek Banerjee for ‘Stolen’ and Sanya Malhotra for ‘Mrs’.

AGENCIES

OTT CATEGORIES

Best Director - OTT film: Karan Tejpal (‘Stolen’)

Best Script - OTT film: Stolen (Karan Tejpal, Gaurav Dhingra, Swapnil Salkar (AGADBUMB))

Other Winners of Chetak Screen Awards 2026

Feature Film Categories

Best Actor in a Supporting Role (Female): Shalini Vatsa (‘Homebound’)

Best Actor in a Supporting Role (Male): Akshaye Khanna (‘Dhurandhar’)

Best Action: Dhurandhar (Aejaz Gulab, Sea Young Oh, Yannick Ben & Ramazan Bulut)

Best Background Score: Dhurandhar (Shashwat Sachdev)

Best Choreography: Dhurandhar (Shararat-Vijay Ganguly)

Best Cinematography: Dhurandhar (Vikash Nowlakha)

Best Dialogue: Dhurandhar (Aditya Dhar)

Best Editing: Dhurandhar (Shivkumar V Panicker)

Best Film for Gender Sensitivity: Haq (Vineet Jain, Vishal Gurnani, Harman Baweja, Juhi Parekh Mehta, Amrita Pandey, Suparn S Varma, Rowena Baweja & Sandeep Singh)

Best Film Writing (Story & Screenplay): Homebound (Basharat Peer, Neeraj Ghaywan & Sumit Roy)

Best Song: Saiyaara - Title Track (‘Saiyaara’; Tanishk Bagchi, Faheem Abdullah & Arslan Nizami)

Best Playback Singer (Male): Saiyaara (‘Saiyaara’ Title Track; Faheem Abdullah)

Best Playback Singer (Fe-

male): Saiyaara (‘Saiyaara’ Title Track; Shreya Ghoshal)

Best Production Design: Dhurandhar (Saini S Johray)

Best Sound Design: Dhurandhar (Bishwadeep Chatterjee)

Best Special Effects: Dhurandhar (Envision VFX, Philm CGI, Resonance Digital, Dhruvi Ranjan Sahoo, Vishal Tyagi & Raza Mohammed Shaikh)

Breakthrough Debut Director: Shazia Iqbal (‘Dhadak 2’)

Breakthrough New Actor (Female): Aneet Padda (‘Saiyaara’)

Breakthrough New Actor (Male): Ahaan Panday (‘Saiyaara’)